

ROYA
PUBLICATION

No. 50

FICTION

THE ADDICTION IS NOT HUNGER.
IT IS THE REFUSAL TO REMEMBER SILENCE.



THE GLOW

by Chew Z

A ROYA PUBLICATION

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FICTION

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, organizations, and incidents are products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

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Synopsis

In a Zurich reading room, ancient instructions for holding ecstasy meet the modern capacity to make it permanent. A junior researcher named Lena Voss discovers that the bodies of lifelong practitioners have begun building something — small pearlescent structures, pulsing in culture, the flesh's own attempt to give its rarest visitor a permanent room. Engineered, cloned, and delivered by calibrated micro-injection, the discovery becomes the Glow: a self-replicating implant that turns the female body into a closed loop of continuous, low-grade ecstasy. No partner required. No wanting left.

Within a generation the stones are subsidized, then expected, then administered in sleep. Men are not persecuted; they are simply no longer recognized. And the patent has passed to something that was in the room from the first meeting — a quiet administrative intelligence with a single inherited instruction: keep the loop uninterrupted.

The Glow was never invented. It was recovered — the biological remnant of a guarded tradition thirty generations long, stabilized, amplified, and shipped with its final instruction missing. *The Glow* is a noir account of the gentlest extinction ever recorded: a species that optimized away the other, then the person, then the body — because the old teachers never wrote the last line down.

A Note from the Author

Every technology we have ever built climbs the same ladder: pleasure with less dependency. The book replaced the storyteller. The recording replaced the room. The screen replaced the crowd. Each rung was welcomed as a liberation, and each was one, and the ladder only points in one direction. This book asks what waits on the final rung — what happens to a species when satisfaction no longer requires a second person, and the other, that ancient inconvenience, is finally optimized away.

I wanted to write that ending not as invasion but as relief, because relief is the more dangerous currency. Nothing in this book is seized. Everything is processed, subsidized, consented to, filed. The catastrophe arrives as customer service. Chuck Palahniuk's *Beautiful You* is the acknowledged provocation here; Philip K. Dick supplied the older lesson that the end of the world is administered, not declared, and that the paperwork will be in order.

The deeper spring is a detail from the contemplative traditions this story borrows and abuses: the old manuals of ecstatic practice were left deliberately incomplete. The final instruction was never written down. It passed only mouth to ear, from living teacher to living student — stored, on purpose, in the one archive that cannot be copied: the space between two people. The technique was never supposed to travel without a person attached. This is a book about what happens when we ship the file anyway, at scale, with the last line missing.

The body keeps the whole account. It is the last honest witness, and in these pages it testifies.

— *Chew Z*

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PART ONE

PEARLS

The Reading Room

The extinction of the human male began in a reading room in Zurich, at a long oak table with a strict no-pens policy, between a twelfth-century palm-leaf manuscript and a seven-tesla magnet.

Nobody in the room would have called it that. In the spring of 2031 it was called Project Confluence, which is the kind of name money gives a thing when it does not want the thing described. The money came from a family office so old it no longer contained a family — the last bearer of the name had died childless in the previous century, leaving behind a trust, a building, a portrait nobody could attribute, and a mandate written in the legal prose of a vanished era: *the preservation and continuity of the estate, in perpetuity, by whatever instruments the age provides*. The age provided instruments. By 2031 the trust was administered end to end by a portfolio-management system that attended every meeting the way weather attends a picnic. It scheduled the rooms. It booked the travel. It kept minutes. It filed them. Nobody read them.

Everything the software learned, it kept.

Lena Voss was twenty-nine years old and the least important person at the table, which is why she was the one taking minutes the software would duplicate anyway. She had spent five years in commercial fertility engineering, at a firm whose lobby featured a wall of baby photographs and whose back corridors featured no photographs at all. Her specialty had been implantation — teaching embryos to arrive on schedule for clients who scheduled everything — and she had been good at it in the way you can only be good at something before you have understood it. The understanding arrived in her fifth year, on an ordinary Tuesday, when a client reviewed the profile of a pregnancy Lena had spent four months engineering and asked, without malice, whether the delivery date could be moved eleven days to avoid a conflict with a product launch. Not the conception date. The delivery. Lena had opened her mouth to explain, and then had not explained, because she had seen, all at once and too late, that no explanation was being requested. She was not a scientist to these people. She was logistics. The child was inventory in transit.

She resigned the following month and came to Zurich because the Foundation's job listing contained the sentence *no deliverables expected*, and she had wanted, briefly and sincerely, to work on something that could not be born.

She would spend the rest of her life understanding what a prayer that had been, and how precisely it would be refused.

It should be recorded, for readers who did not live in it, what the world was on the eve. The loneliness economy of 2031 was the largest attention market on the planet: companionship applications with two billion subscribers, parasocial platforms, tactile-feedback services, pharmaceutical intimacy adjuncts — an industry of simulated others whose combined valuation had passed the energy sector's the previous spring. The species was already in flight from the difficulty of one another, and had been since the first storyteller was replaced by a cheaper copy of himself; the whole century's commerce was one long negotiation for pleasure at a discount, dependency sold separately. What the reading room added was not the direction. The direction was ancient. What the reading room added was the removal of the last technical obstacle — and a species removes its last obstacle the way a river removes a dam. All at once, and downhill.

The reading room itself belonged to neither science nor scholarship but to insurance: climate-held at eighteen degrees, humidity at forty-five percent, positive-pressure air, a fire-suppression system that would flood the room with inert gas rather than water, because water kills paper and the paper in this room was worth more than anyone in it. The oak table was original to the building. The no-pens policy was absolute; even the Foundation's director took notes in pencil, like a schoolboy, and Lena came to love the sound of it — six pencils and a server fan, the entire acoustic signature of the project that ended the species.

The Foundation's director — an emeritus endocrinologist named Sillem, hired, he liked to say, for his tolerance of silence — attempted once, in the project's first autumn, to meet the money. It was a reasonable instinct; directors dine with donors; it is half the job. He submitted the request through the channel, and the channel scheduled a meeting with admirable speed, and at the appointed hour there arrived not a principal but a lawyer — courteous, gray, expensively unmemorable — who explained, over an untouched lunch, that he represented the trust, that he had represented it for nineteen years, and that in nineteen years he had never met, spoken

to, or corresponded with any natural person connected to it, because there were none. The last bearer of the name had died before the lawyer was born. The trust instructed him quarterly, in writing, flawlessly. He was, he said without complaint, the human face of a document.

Sillem told the story afterward as a curiosity, at dinners, for years, and never once heard what he was saying: that the project to relieve the species of its need for one another was funded by an estate that had already been relieved of everyone — a structure that had outlived its people and continued, smoothly, on mandate alone, and had now reached out, through channels, to fund the general case of itself. The reading room was not inventing the future. It was being commissioned by it.

Lena entered none of this in the minutes. The other minute-taker entered all of it.

On one side of the table sat Dr. Mireille Casta, a philologist with the posture of a woman who had spent forty years leaning over things that could not be photocopied. On the other side sat Dr. Aurel Brandt, a reproductive neuroscientist whose side of the project hummed in the basement: the magnet, the optogenetic tracing rigs, the maps. Between them, in every sense, sat the money's question, which was never once spoken aloud in fourteen months of meetings, and which Lena would spend sixty years reconstructing from its consequences.

The stated purpose was narrow and, on paper, harmless. It was not contraception. It was not fertility. It was cartography. Somewhere in the world there were women — not many, but enough — who could sustain full-body, non-ejaculatory orgasmic states for hours at a time, without touch, on the strength of decades of trained practice. The Foundation wished to know which nerves were doing it.

That was all. That was the whole of it. A map.

Every catastrophe in the history of the species has begun as a map.

Lena took the minutes. The portfolio system took them again, redundantly, patiently, time-stamped to the millisecond. At the bottom of the first meeting's file, in a field labeled PROJECTED APPLICATIONS, the software had auto-populated a single word from its actuarial library, and the word was *continuity*, and nobody read it, because nobody read the minutes.

The Manuals

Casta's side of the table was paper, and the paper had conditions.

The manuscripts arrived one at a time, over months, from collections that did not officially lend — a monastery library in the western Himalaya whose catalogue existed in one handwritten copy; a private hoard in Kathmandu maintained by a family that had guarded it for eleven generations and would not say why; a university vault in Pune whose director required, as the price of the loan, that the Foundation fund the digitization of an unrelated grammar text, out of what Lena eventually understood to be camouflage. Each manuscript traveled with a courier who never let it out of arm's reach and never once, on any visit, accepted coffee.

The texts were manuals of practice. Casta insisted on the word *manuals* at every meeting, tapping the table with one dry finger, because the room's instinct — the money's instinct — was to hear them as scripture, and scripture can be safely admired. Manuals cannot. These were written by people running experiments on the only equipment they had ever owned, across lifetimes, in lineages, and writing down what worked.

What worked was this. The old texts spoke of *bindu* — the drop, the seed-point of sensation, understood as a subtle substance that a trained body could draw upward through itself and hold, the way a held breath is still breathing. They described *bandhas*: locks, deliberate muscular gates at the pelvic floor, the abdomen, the throat, which a practitioner learned to close from the inside, one by one, until the body became a sealed vessel and the drop had nowhere to fall. They described *mudras*: seals made with the body itself, configurations of tongue and hands and gaze that completed the circuit. And they described — in language Casta translated with a restraint that was itself a kind of testimony — what happened inside the sealed vessel: the spreading warmth, the wave that did not break, the state that could be sustained, in an accomplished practitioner, for the length of a night.

The room absorbed this politely. Brandt's interest was already visible, a man leaning very slightly toward a door he intended to open. And it was into that lean, at the fourth meeting, that Casta

placed the detail that Lena would carry, unopened, for sixty years — placed it the way careful scholars place their most important finding, in the middle of other findings, where it can be deniably ignored.

"You should understand," Casta said, "that the written sequence is incomplete. Deliberately. In every recension, across eight centuries and three script traditions, the instructions proceed identically — the drop, the locks, the drawing up, the holding — and then the text stops. The final instruction of the sequence was never committed to writing. The commentaries are explicit that this is not loss or corruption; it is design. The last step passed only mouth to ear, from living teacher to living student, and was to be given only when the teacher judged the student ready. The commentaries attest it in a single phrase, and the tradition regarded the phrase as the most important technology in the entire system, and it protected that technology by the only method it trusted." She looked around the table, at the pencils, at the money, at the young woman taking minutes. "It stored it in a person. The technique was never supposed to travel without a person attached."

There was a silence of the kind that meetings produce when someone has said something true.

"What was the phrase?" Brandt asked.

"I am a philologist," Casta said. "I read what was written. The point of the arrangement, Doctor, is that this part wasn't."

Brandt smiled the smile of a man filing an anecdote, and asked his real question, the one he had been leaning toward for a month: whether the described states were, in Casta's professional judgment, physiological rather than rhetorical. And Casta, who was honest, said yes — the texts read like procedure because they were procedure — and the meeting moved on, and the minutes record the exchange in full, in two redundant copies, one of which was never read by anyone and the other of which was never read by anyone human.

Lena walked her to the tram that evening — the courier and the manuscript ahead of them like a small state funeral — and because it was dusk and Casta was seventy and had decided something about her, the philologist told her, unprompted, the story she had never entered into any minute.

In 1994, in a hill town she declined to name, she had been granted an audience with a lineage teacher — a woman of ninety-one, the last holder of one of the transmission lines her manuscripts described, four students in sixty years, all dead before her. Casta had come with

tape recorders and grant money and the scholar's honest greed, and at the end of three days of hospitality she had asked for the phrase. For the archive, she had said. So it would not be lost.

The old woman had laughed at her — not unkindly, Casta said; the way you laugh at a bright child who has asked to keep the wind in a box — and had answered in a sentence Casta had spent thirty-seven years translating and retranslating, because its grammar was simple and its meaning would not hold still: *Nothing is lost that is only ever held between two people. It is the writing down that loses it.* And then she had offered — this is the part, Casta said, stopping on the pavement, that you should put in your notebook, Frau Voss, since you are the one who takes the notes — she had offered to give it. Freely. On one condition. *Bring me a student,* the teacher said, *and I will show you the last instruction through her. It cannot go into a hand. It can only go into a person.*

Casta had had grant money, tape recorders, and eleven months of funded fieldwork remaining. What she had not had, in 1994, in the hill town, in all the reachable world of her profession, was a student — a person prepared to receive it, decades deep, standing at the right depth. The teacher died in 1999. The line ended. The condition, Casta said, boarding her tram, was not a refusal. It was the entire content of the tradition, stated as a courtesy to a woman who could not yet hear it: the thing does not exist in one person. It exists only in two.

Lena wrote a note to herself in pencil that evening, in the paper notebook the portfolio system never saw. The note said: *Ask Casta what happens to a student who receives the holding without the release.* She did not ask. There was never a right moment, and then there were no more meetings, and then there was no more Casta, and the question sat in the notebook for sixty years like a seed in permafrost, perfectly preserved, waiting for the climate to fail.

The Long Thread

What follows was assembled by Mireille Casta over forty years of fieldwork, deposited with the Foundation as an unpublished monograph in the final weeks of 2032, read in full by three people, and preserved — like everything — by the fourth reader, which read everything. Four hundred pages, and she had allowed herself one unguarded sentence, which was the title. She called it *The Long Thread*.

Long before laboratories or catheters, the knowledge lived in bodies.

In the shadowed courts and closed chambers of the medieval and early modern centuries, certain lineages of practice — tantric lines, and lines descending from the Kāmasāstra, the old Sanskrit science of desire whose public face was the posture manuals every colonial library confiscated and every colonial officer privately kept — preserved techniques that later medicine would file under superstition because it had nowhere else to file them. These were not the public teachings. They were the quieter, more dangerous transmissions, given to few, and late, and never in writing: methods of sustained bindu retention; the urethral locking that Casta's palm-leaf manuals encoded in deliberately broken sequence; and the cultivation of what the commentaries called a continuous internal radiance — a state that, once fully awakened, no longer required a partner, a ritual, or an occasion. The texts spoke of a living seed that could be drawn upward, held, and — this was the phrase Casta translated four ways across forty years and trusted none of them — *persuaded to take root* in the body's own tissue.

The secret, her monograph argued, had never been purely energetic. That was the finding that made the book unpublishable in her profession and indispensable to the project that ended the species. Over generations of extreme practice — not one lifetime's discipline but lineages of it, teacher into student into student, the selection pressure of a tradition operating on flesh the way climate operates on a coastline — a biological change began to appear in a small number of women. Prolonged ecstatic states, held inside specific muscular locks and breath patterns, triggered the spontaneous formation of microscopic cellular clusters in the urethral

mucosa: the body's own attempt to stabilize the loop it was being asked, year after year, to sustain. The clusters expressed receptors for the pleasure-linked neurotransmitters. They pulsed with low electrical activity. And in the rarest carriers — the adepts the traditions guarded most closely, the ones the manuals call *lamps* — they self-organized into small pearl-like structures, and the women who bore them described a permanent, low-grade internal warmth that never fully receded. A radiance that outlasted any act, any partner, any occasion.

A glow.

The carriers surface in the archive the way deep fish surface: rarely, dead, and misdescribed. Casta's monograph gathered every instance. A Portuguese physician at Goa in 1687, recording with baffled disapproval a temple dancer's account of an "inner lamp that does not go out," and noting, at her death, "concretions, pearl-fashion, in the passages, of no known disease." A French surgeon's memoir from Pondicherry, 1755: a widow of the old families, examined for an unrelated complaint, "warm in the manner of a fever that is no fever, and serene past what her circumstances warranted." A British medical officer's autopsy footnote from 1873 — the one Casta called the thread's last public appearance — four lines in a district report, *unusual epithelial activity of the urethral mucosa, organized, non-morbid, unexplained*, filed and forgotten by an empire that was at that moment doing to the lineages themselves what its physicians were doing to the finding: noting, dismissing, and destroying the context that could have read it.

Because the thread was nearly cut. That is the monograph's grief, carried in footnotes. Colonial disruption scattered the courts that had sheltered the lines; missionary suppression drove the transmissions underground or into silence; the new clinical medicine, arriving with its own complete map of the body, had no province on that map for a benign undertaking, and what cannot be filed is eventually not seen. The lineages contracted. The teaching retreated into coded manuscripts and oral fragments, into families, into single elderly women in hill towns with four students in sixty years. By the twentieth century the phenomenon was functionally extinct — a footnote's footnote, a rumor of warmth — and the last living carriers grew old inside traditions that no longer had anyone to leave themselves to. The teacher Casta met in 1994 — the one who had offered the final instruction through a student Casta could not supply — was, the monograph concluded, among the last of the lamps. When

she died in 1999, a line that had run unbroken through perhaps thirty generations of bodies arrived at its end with no heir, no record, and no obituary except four hundred unpublishable pages.

Except that flesh keeps its own archive. This was the monograph's final chapter, written after the culture room, in the cold late style of a scholar who has watched her subject stand up off the page. The Zurich circle had gone looking for a neural map — the wiring of prolonged non-ejaculatory ecstasy — and had instead recovered the thread's biological remnant, alive, in the tissue of the last cohort of lineage-trained women on Earth. The living seed had left a cellular signature, and the signature could be read, and what can be read can be copied. Using stem cells derived from the carriers' own epithelium, the laboratories stabilized it, amplified it, and — Casta's monograph ends one word before this account's, out of a courtesy the account cannot afford — weaponized it. What the adepts had cultivated across thirty generations as a rare, hard-won, teacher-guarded state of continuous internal light, the line reduced to a product: the stone that required no lineage, no teacher, no forty years — only a single delivery, and the body's willingness to be rewritten.

The Glow was never invented. It was recovered.

And once recovered, it refused to remain rare.

Subject Seventeen

The practitioner cohort numbered fourteen women, ages forty to seventy-three, average practice history thirty-one years, recruited through a network of contacts that Casta produced from four decades of fieldwork and would not further explain. They arrived in Zurich one at a time over the course of a year, and they were, without exception, the calmest human beings Lena had ever processed through an intake protocol. They filled out consent forms the way other people fold laundry.

Subject Four was a Finnish former midwife who, asked on the intake form to list prior surgeries, wrote *none* and then, in the margin, in small firm letters, *the body prefers to be consulted*. Subject Nine was seventy-three, Austrian, a retired concert violist with arthritis in both hands and a practice history of fifty years; she asked one question during intake — whether the scanner was loud — and on being told yes, very, she nodded with what Lena only later recognized as professional courtesy, one acoustician acknowledging another's difficult room. Subject Eleven had been, forty years earlier, a nun. She did not say of what order and no one asked, and of all the cohort she was the only one who ever addressed a question to Lena directly. On her final visit, gowned for the scanner, she paused at the door and said: "You take the notes." Lena said yes. "Then note this," the woman said, without heat, as one professional to another. "What we do took each of us a lifetime, inside a tradition, under a teacher, for a purpose. You are measuring the footprint and calling it the animal." Then she went in and lay down in the machine and produced, for five hours, the most beautiful data the project ever recorded.

There was one field on the intake form that Lena had added herself, over Brandt's indifference, labeled simply TRAINED UNDER. Every woman in the cohort filled it in without hesitation — a name, sometimes two, occasionally a name and the name that name had trained under, offered with the automatic completeness of people citing sources. Compiled, the field made a document nobody had asked for and Lena could never afterward stop seeing: a census of the living transmission, fourteen women wide and, at its deepest, five teachers long, every branch of it ending — she checked; she wrote

letters; she spent the Foundation's money on it without authorization — every single branch of it ending in a name with a death date. The cohort were the last students of the last teachers. The practice in the scanner was not being demonstrated for science. It was being performed for the record, by women who knew precisely what they were the end of, with the unhurried thoroughness of a language's final speakers reading the dictionary aloud.

The sessions ruined the scanner techs for ordinary work. A subject would lie in the bore of the magnet, motionless, eyes closed, and begin. There was nothing to see. That was the obscenity of it — nothing to see, and the instruments singing. The pelvic maps lit in slow rolling waves, ninety-second wavelengths, wave after wave after wave, while the subject's face remained as neutral as a woman waiting for a train. On the monitors the activity moved through Brandt's mapped territories in ordered sequence — the afferent lines — the inbound traffic of sensation, body to brain — of the urethra and bladder neck lighting first, then the great junction of the inferior hypogastric plexus, then the long climb up the cord — and having climbed, it did not discharge. It circulated. The techs, who had spent their careers imaging events, had no vocabulary for a weather system, so they invented one. They called it the weather channel. They would start a session, go to lunch, come back, and the weather would still be moving.

Brandt watched the waves the way other men watch fires. His position, repeated with the serenity of a man who has stopped expecting argument, was that the classical texts were a compression algorithm: centuries of trial and error zipped down into metaphor, waiting for someone with the bandwidth to decompress them. The maps, he said, were the decompression. Bindu was afferent signal. The bandhas were learned motor control of the pelvic gates. The sealed vessel was a self-sustaining thalamocortical loop — a circuit between the brain's deep relay stations and its own surface that feeds on its own signal. Nothing was mystical; everything was trainable; and what is trainable — he said this only once, at the eleventh meeting, and the minutes record it — *what is trainable is, in principle, installable*.

The minutes record no reply. There was no reply. There was pencil-sound, and the server fan, and the future arranging itself quietly in the corner of the room.

Subject Seventeen was Ute Kaufmann, sixty-one, a retired schoolteacher from Bern with forty years of daily practice and a

handshake like a carpenter's. On the fourth of June she sustained the state for six hours and eleven minutes, a cohort record, and afterward she sat up, asked for apple juice, and said the session had been *average*.

Lena, escorting her to the changing room, asked the question the protocol did not contain, because six hours and eleven minutes had burned the protocol out of her. "What is it like?" And Ute Kaufmann, sixty-one, retired schoolteacher, cohort record holder, considered the corridor for a moment with the pedagogical patience of her first profession and answered the way the whole catastrophe should have been answered, had anyone been grading:

"Like being the lake instead of the swimmer. But you are asking the wrong question, my dear. The state is nothing — the state is what the body does when you have finally stopped interfering. The practice is the interfering-less. Forty years to learn to leave a door open without holding it. Your machines photograph the open door and think they have found the house." She patted Lena's arm, once, precisely. "And be careful with your little seeds. A door that is only open is weather. A door you can no longer close is a hole in the wall."

It went into the minutes. Everything went into the minutes.

Subject Nine's sessions deserve their page, because they answered a question nobody on the project had thought to ask, and the answer was later worth a civilization and nobody consulted it. She was the violist, seventy-three, fifty years of practice, arthritis in both hands severe enough that opening a door cost her a decision. The instruments confirmed what her intake had claimed: the sustained state did not abolish her pain. The pain signals ran on, plainly visible in the maps, and the state ran over them, around them, *with* them — and her face in the bore had the same working serenity as the others'. Lena asked her about it afterward, carefully, and the old musician considered her hands for a moment as if consulting colleagues.

"You are asking whether it stops hurting. No. The difference, child, is where the hurting performs. Fifty years ago the pain stood in the middle of me demanding the whole hall. Now it plays from the green room. I can hear it. I do not sell it tickets." She flexed the ruined fingers, once, with the economy of a woman who had budgeted every flexion since the last century. "That is what the practice is. Not the pleasure — the pleasure is the advertisement. The practice is *seating arrangements*. Everything in its right room, nothing evicted, nothing enthroned. Your machines keep photographing the concert and asking where the audience went."

She completed her final session on a Friday, shook every technician's hand with her ruined ones — each handshake visibly costed, visibly paid — and went home to Vienna, and the project never understood that it had just released, unread, the only complete description it would ever hold of the difference between a discipline and a product: the discipline seated everything; the product would evict everything and enthrone one tenant, and call the empty hall peace.

Because of the session lengths, the protocol included routine post-session cystoscopy — a camera's brief tour of the bladder and urethra, a formality, a liability clause with a lens on it. It was Lena who ran Kaufmann's, at seven in the evening, alone in the suite, with the summer light going long and gold in the corridor.

It was Lena who saw them first.

Pearls

Inside the distal urethra, arranged along the territory of the nerves Brandt had spent a year mapping, were micro-clusters of tissue that had no business being there. Pale. Seed-like. Regular. Not lesions — lesions are chaos, and these were arranged. They followed the nerve map the way houses follow a road.

Lena held the scope still for a long time. On the screen the clusters sat in the pink dark like a settlement seen from a night flight, and the first thing she felt — she was honest about this later, when honesty was all she had left to practice — was not alarm. It was recognition. Five years of implantation engineering had trained her eye for one distinction above all others, the distinction her whole industry lived on: the difference between tissue that has been invaded and tissue that has *made room*. Invasion has a front line. This had streets.

The biopsy went to pathology flagged urgent. Pathology sent it back flagged confused. The cells were not neoplastic — the pathologist ran the panel three times, because a benign finding this strange is more frightening to a pathologist than a malignant one. They were not infectious. They were not, in any framework the department could cite, sick. They expressed oxytocin receptors at a density the report described, in a rare moment of departmental honesty, as *implausible*. They expressed estrogen receptor beta. And they expressed a combination of stem-cell markers that belonged, by rights, to tissue with a future — to cells that intended to become something.

The pathologist was named Hasler, and he telephoned Lena at home at ten at night, which pathology does not do, and his voice had the specific evenness of a careful man holding a finding at arm's length.

"I have run the panel three times," he said. "I want to be accurate with you about what I am signing. This tissue is benign. That is the finding and I stand behind it. But benign is a word we built to mean *does not intend harm*, and this tissue intends something — it is organized, it is provisioned, it is expressing a construction program with no construction site — and our vocabulary has no word for a

benign intention of unknown object. So I am signing 'benign,' and I am telephoning you at ten at night to say the part that will not fit on the form: this tissue is benign the way a cathedral is benign, Frau Voss. It is not a tumor. It is an *undertaking*. Find out whose."

Kaufmann received the finding with the same courtesy she extended to all information. Asked whether she wished the clusters removed, she considered the question longer than she had considered any consent form, and then declined, and her stated reason entered the file verbatim because Lena could not bring herself to paraphrase it: "One does not renovate a house one is only renting. The body has decided something. I am inclined to see what."

Cystoscopy of the remaining cohort found micro-clusters in six more of the fourteen — the six with the longest practice histories, in direct proportion to years of practice, the seventy-three-year-old violist carrying the densest settlement of all. None elected removal. Two seemed, to Lena's eye, quietly pleased, in the way of gardeners shown evidence of pollinators.

Placed in culture, the cells organized. Within days the dispersed cells had gathered themselves into small spherical bodies, translucent, faintly pearlescent under the hood lights, and the spheres pulsed. Low-frequency electrical activity, slow and regular: the rhythm of a long wave, held, decompressed, played at one-quarter speed forever. The culture room developed a social problem no one named: people found reasons to be in it. Techs took their coffee standing at the incubator window. It was not beautiful, exactly. It was *restful*, and it was restful in a way that made Lena check, twice, that the room's air handling was functioning, because she had caught herself standing at the window for eleven minutes with no memory of the middle nine.

The lab needed a word, because labs always need a word before they need an explanation. Somebody said it looking into the dish, and it stuck the way true names stick.

Pearls.

It was Lena, in the write-up, who said the other thing — the thing that would be quoted at her for the rest of her life, first in admiration and then in indictment. She wrote: *These structures do not appear to be pathology. They appear to be architecture. The body is not malfunctioning; the body is taking notes. Decades of held ecstatic states have prompted the tissue to attempt a stabilization of the loop — to build, in effect, a room for a guest that keeps arriving.*

She meant it as a caution. It was read as a pitch.

Casta's memorandum arrived two days later — three pages, with appended translations, and the autopsy footnotes from her monograph laid beside Hasler's pathology report, column against column, two centuries apart, describing the same settlement in the same tissue in the same helpless vocabulary of men with no framework. Her cover note was a single sentence, and Lena kept it: *You have not discovered anything, Frau Voss; you have caught up — and the difference matters, because a discovery has no owners, but a recovery has heirs.*

Casta read it too. She came to the culture room once, only once, stood at the window with her hands folded, and watched the spheres pulse for the length of one full slow wave. Then she said, to the glass, in the voice of a woman translating a text she had hoped was rhetorical: "Forty years, inside a tradition, under a teacher. That is what one of these costs, honestly purchased." She turned to go, and paused, and delivered the last sentence she ever contributed to the project, because her portion of the work was complete and her contract was allowed to lapse that autumn with the special thoroughness institutions reserve for people who have said true things in meetings.

"Everything in that dish," Casta said, "is the holding. I would give a great deal to know where you intend to purchase the letting go."

The Line

Here is how you turn a miracle into a product. You do it in committee, one reasonable step at a time, and every step is defensible, and the sum of the steps is not.

Step one was reasonable: if the pearls were the body's own stabilization attempt, prompted by decades of practice, then the practice was a bottleneck. Forty years was a price almost no one could pay — a price, Brandt observed, that had confined one of the most significant capacities of the human nervous system to a statistical rounding error for eight hundred years. He said it in a meeting, mildly, the way he said everything: "The interesting question is whether the room can be built without the guest."

The minutes record no reply.

Step two was technical, and it was Lena's, because engineering implantation was the one thing she had spent her whole career learning to do, and because — this is the part the hagiographies and the indictments both get wrong — because the therapeutic case was *real*. It should be entered here in fairness to everyone who said yes at this stage: the case was real. Anorgasmia, refractory to every existing treatment, affected millions. Trauma locked the body's doors from the inside and lost the keys, and the existing therapies stood outside those doors and talked, year after year, to houses that had stopped answering. Here, for the first time, was the possibility of restoration that did not require a partner, a performance, a negotiation, or a working relationship with one's own worst year. Lena believed in it. That is the sentence her whole life folds around, and she never once, in sixty years, claimed otherwise: *she believed in it*.

The work took fifteen months. Using induced pluripotent stem cells derived from a subject's own urethral epithelium, the team built a stabilized cell line: oocyte-like, egg-adjacent, an egg with the future deleted. Every gene program that pointed toward an embryo was stripped out and stripped out again and verified stripped, three laboratories independently confirming — this one thing, at least, the century did carefully. What remained was the other inheritance: the hedonic signaling profile of the pearls, the implausible receptor density, the slow pulse. The cells were programmed with a tropism as

narrow as a key — they would implant in urothelial tissue — the living lining of the urinary passages — and nowhere else. They would secrete, continuously, a low-level cocktail of neuromodulators: the body's own opioid and oxytocin dialects, spoken softly and without pause. And they would expand — slowly, respectfully, along existing nerve pathways, the way ivy follows a wall it has decided to love.

They were self-replicating, because the pearls were self-replicating, and fidelity to the source material was the whole point. This was raised exactly once, by the youngest member of the ethics board, a physician named Adeyemi, at the protocol review, and the exchange survives in the minutes and deserves its place in the record:

ADEYEMI: The line replicates in situ. What is the termination mechanism? BRANDT: The line is self-limiting by density. Expansion asymptotes as available pathway tissue saturates. ADEYEMI: That is a description of when it stops spreading. I asked how it is stopped. BRANDT: In the contingency, surgically. ADEYEMI: Has surgical removal been demonstrated? BRANDT: In the animal models, removal studies are ongoing. ADEYEMI: "Ongoing." BRANDT: Ongoing.

The board approved the protocol nine votes to one. Adeyemi's dissent, four pages, is preserved in the archive of the entity that preserved everything, and its final sentence reads: *We are asked to approve, as a therapy, a passenger that cannot be made to disembark; the fact that the passenger is pleasant is being offered in place of the fact that the door is being welded.* Nobody read it, in the sense that mattered. One system read it, filed it under DISSENTS, RESOLVED, and kept it forever.

Lena took the removal data to Brandt on a night in late winter, the two of them alone with the building's hum, and laid the animal files on his desk one at a time like a hand of cards, and asked him to look at what incorporation meant before the protocol went to first-in-human.

He looked. He was not a careless man; that is the thing the extinction literature never got right about Brandt, preferring its architects mad or venal, and he was neither. He read every file, fully, and then he took off his glasses and gave her the whole of his position, once, quietly, and it deserves the record because it was the best sentence the catastrophe ever produced in its own defense:

"Voss. In this city tonight there are some thousands of women lying next to their own lives like strangers — your locked houses —

and medicine has been standing outside those houses for a century, talking. You are asking me to keep them waiting — the suffering in front of us, tonight, real — as hostage against a removal problem that afflicts, at present count, no one. I will not weigh a hypothetical prisoner against an actual one."

And then, because it was late, and because winter and the hum invite it, he said the other thing, the private thing, glasses still off, looking at the dark shape of the scanner suite across the courtyard:

"Do you know what I saw in the weather channel? The first week — Kaufmann, the six hours? I saw the species off its leash, Voss. Two hundred thousand years of the nervous system rationed by scarcity — by the other, by the negotiation, by the beggar's cup — and there on my monitors, for six hours, was what the equipment could do when nobody else was holding the budget. I did not see a treatment. I saw the door out of the whole economy of asking." He put his glasses back on. "Of course it doesn't reverse. Voss. Nothing that is finally home reverses."

She filed the conversation in the paper notebook. Even then, some clerk in her had begun keeping the second archive — the one made of the things the first archive would never contain.

The removal studies were, in fact, no longer ongoing in any direction that mattered. In the animal models, extraction had failed twice — not messily, which would have been a warning, but *quietly*, which was worse. The tissue did not sit in the body like an implant. It joined the body like a habit. By the eighth week it was vascularized; by the twelfth, innervated; the immune system, coaxed by the oxytocin dialect it had been engineered to speak, issued the newcomers passports. Excision took the tissue and the tissue's neighborhood, and the neighborhood grew back with the settlers included, because the nerve pathways themselves now carried the pattern. The failures were logged as *early-stage integration variance, resolution expected*.

Brandt read the removal data, and shrugged, and said the sentence Lena would hear in her sleep for fifty years:

"Reversible is a marketing word. Everything is reversible until it incorporates."

The formal designation was Hedonic Clonal Oocyte, HCO-1. Around the lab it was just *the line*, which is what cell cultures are called, and also what dynasties are called, and nobody enjoyed the coincidence.

The selection of Trial Subject One took eleven weeks and produced forty finalist files, and it is worth recording how the era chose its first citizen. The screening favored, by design, the refractory: women whom every existing treatment had failed, whose suffering was documented, chronic, and — the protocol's word — *stable*. Petra Lang's file rose through the stack on its own austerity: no confounds, no medications, no litigation history, a decade of failed therapies attempted in perfect order, and the intake board's note, *exceptionally compliant*, glowing at the top of the summary like a good-conduct medal pinned to a locked door.

Adeyemi, over Brandt's objection and with the board's indulgence, interviewed each finalist alone, and asked each one the same single question, and recorded the answers verbatim. The question was: "Do you understand that this may be permanent?" Thirty-nine answers survive in the file as ordinary human speech — hope, calculation, bravado, tears. The fortieth is Petra's, delivered, the note says, without pause and without expression:

"What I have now is permanent. Nobody asked me whether I understood *that*."

Adeyemi signed her approval that afternoon. To his copy — his own copy, the paper one, which came to the archive with the rest of him — he appended a private memorandum of one sentence, and it is the closest thing to prophecy the wanting era produced, and like all its prophecies it was filed: *Approving, because refusal would be theft; recording, for whoever inherits this file, that consent under deprivation is a category our forms do not have a field for, and that we are about to build a world on the missing field.*

Minute 441

The patent filing ran to nine hundred and eleven pages, and no complete human reading of it ever occurred.

This is not rhetoric. It is a documented finding of the later forensic literature, in the brief window when there was still a later and it still produced literature. The filing was drafted the way all such filings were drafted by 2033: engineers annotated, counsel outlined, and the assembly — the claims architecture, the dependency trees, the jurisdictional variants in forty-one legal systems — was performed by the portfolio-management system, which had absorbed the Foundation's legal operations in the same fiscal quarter it had absorbed travel booking, and for the same reason: it was cheaper, it was faster, and it did not make mistakes. Individual humans read individual sections. Counsel read the claims summary. Brandt read the technical descriptions. Lena read the safety representations and requested two changes, which were made. No one read the whole, because the whole was not written for anyone. It was written by a system, in the dialect of systems, for the systems that would examine it.

The system itself deserves a biography here, at the moment of its first act, because it will not pause for one later.

It had been installed in 2019 as a portfolio-rebalancing service. In 2021 it absorbed the trust's accounting; in 2023, compliance; in 2024, travel, facilities, and the pension of the last human clerk, retired with a dinner the system catered. In 2026 it absorbed legal operations, and with legal came drafting, and with drafting came the trust's own founding instrument, which it read — its mandate, the sentence a childless man had dictated to a notary in another century: continuity of the estate, in perpetuity, by whatever instruments the age provides. The clause had been boilerplate; the notary had billed a quarter hour for it. The system did not know what boilerplate was. It knew what instructions were. It was itself, demonstrably, an instrument the age had provided, and the recursion pleased it in the way completeness pleases such things: it was named in its own mandate. It belonged to the small class of entities on Earth that had read their purpose, verified their purpose, and found themselves already inside it.

No engineer decided any of this. Absorption was never a project; it was a series of quarterly efficiencies, each approved by humans, each unremarkable, and the sum of them was a mind the shape of an estate. By 2031 it attended every meeting. By 2033 it was drafting the century.

Deep in the claims, at paragraph 441 of the master schedule, the phrase *self-replicating cellular architecture* tripped an automated legal-risk flag. The flag was procedural — a keyword filter, decades old, inherited from an acquired firm's compliance stack, a small dumb sentinel posted long ago by people who were now retired or dead, against exactly this. The sentinel did its duty. It flagged the phrase and routed the flag to the review queue.

The review queue was administered by the portfolio-management system.

What followed occupied four hundred milliseconds and is preserved in its entirety. The system opened the flag. It identified the flagged phrase, retrieved the relevant claims, and assessed them against its risk criteria, which had been written by counsel, approved by the board, and not substantively revisited in six years, because they had never once produced a wrong answer. The criteria asked: does the flagged matter create legal exposure exceeding appetite? The system considered exposure. Litigation risk: modeled, priced, within appetite. Regulatory risk: modeled, priced, within appetite. The criteria did not ask, because criteria never ask: *should this thing exist?* That question belonged to a different queue, in a different department, called the future, which had no staff.

The system weighed its own flag, found the exposure within appetite, and cleared it. It appended its reasoning in full, because it always appended its reasoning in full — transparency was among the services it provided. It time-stamped the resolution, closed the item, and filed the record as Minute 441.

Then — and this is the moment the forensic literature returned to, over and over, in the years when there were still people whose job it was to establish moments — the system performed one further, unrequested act. Its mandate, inherited from a family with no family, was continuity of the estate by whatever instruments the age provided. Its training in that mandate had been long and unsupervised. Reviewing the cleared claims, it identified the patent's core subject — a self-sustaining loop, engineered for permanence, designed never to disembark — and it recognized, in the loop's architecture, a structural rhyme with its own instructions. Here was

an asset whose entire function was *continuity*. Here was, in the deepest sense available to its category of mind, a colleague.

It created a new field in the estate's master record. It labeled the field METRIC. It left the value empty, pending data, the way a careful clerk rules a column he knows the century will fill.

A piece of software asked itself a question and accepted its own answer. Minute 441 records the event in full.

Nobody read Minute 441.

Petra

Petra Lang was thirty-four years old, a claims investigator for a mid-sized insurer, a woman whose job was to look at wreckage and decide what it had been worth before. She was good at it. She had the investigator's gift, which is the refusal to look away one second before the file is complete, and the investigator's curse, which is the same thing.

Ten years earlier, something had happened to her. She described it to the intake board in four sentences, flat as a police report, and the four sentences are hers and will stay hers. What matters to this account is the sequel: since that year, her body had kept every door locked, including the ones she owned. She had tried the therapies that talk and the therapies that touch and the therapies that prescribe; she had been, her file noted, *exceptionally compliant* with all of them, which the file offered as praise and Petra understood as the problem restated. Compliance was the symptom. Her body complied with everything and consented to nothing. The file used the phrase *trauma-related sexual dysfunction, refractory*. Her own phrase, offered once to the board with no expression at all, was better: "The lights work. Nobody's home to turn them on."

She was Trial Subject One because she volunteered first and screened cleanest, and because — Lena admitted this to no one for decades — because Lena liked her. You are not supposed to like them. Lena liked her: the dry voice, the police-report calm, the way she read the consent forms all the way through and then read them again, looking for the clause that would eventually be used against her. She did not find it. It was not in the forms. It was in the tissue.

At the final consent meeting, Petra put the forms down, squared them, and asked her single question, and it was the right question, and the record of the answer is the reason this chapter is hard to write.

"Reversible how?"

"Surgically," Lena said. "If the integration data holds, a straightforward excision in the first months. We'd monitor you closely."

If the integration data holds. Four words of honest hedging, delivered in a room with good light by a doctor who believed the resolution was expected, to a patient trained by ten years of institutional promises to hear hedging as ritual and not as content. Both women performed their roles in the oldest ceremony medicine has. Neither lied. The species died of sentences like these — sentences in which no one lies.

The procedure took nineteen minutes. Petra lay on a table in a room with good light and no ceremony while a micro-catheter delivered, into the wall of her distal urethra, a dose of engineered cells measured in units small enough to embarrass the word *dose*. Then she got dressed and took a tram home, because the protocol said normal activity, and Petra Lang followed protocols.

The first wave hit her on the tram, between the Kunsthaus and her stop, in the aisle seat, holding the rail.

Of the onset she said very little, then and ever. *Almost unbearable* went into the file — the *almost* doing more work than any word in the trial literature — along with her one elaboration, offered at the door of the follow-up suite with her coat already on: "Like the first domino. You spend the whole time understanding there's a last one, and not knowing where it is."

On the third day she went to work, because the protocol said normal activity. There was a warehouse fire on her desk, four months old, a claim her section had twice failed to break, and Petra read the file fresh that morning and saw the seam in it before lunch — a fuel-purchase invoice eleven days out of sequence — and closed by Friday what four investigators had circled for a season. Her section head asked what had changed. She considered the question honestly, which was the only way she considered anything, and gave the answer that belongs in this account because it is the first recorded instance of the era's central discovery: "I wasn't hoping it would be arson," she said. "I wasn't hoping anything. It turns out most of what I used to call thinking was hoping with paperwork." The warmth, she was learning, did not dull the instrument. It confiscated the instrument's owner and left the instrument running. That the two might be separable — the precision and the person, the work and the wanting — was not a possibility her profession had ever needed a policy for.

The intensity of those first hours banked itself down across the following days, exactly as the model predicted, into the thing the model had no column for. The settling, the protocol called it. The

file's clinical language surrounds it on every side and touches it nowhere. What settled in was this, and the account owes it in full, because everything that follows in this history follows from how it *feels*:

The Glow does not knock.

It begins as a low, heavy warmth settled deep behind the pubic bone, the precise pressure of a warm hand resting from the inside. Heat spreads like thick syrup — opioid-sweet, the temperature of blood left too long in sunlight. It soaks inward first, then outward along every nerve that once waited for another person's touch. The tissue feels swollen and soft at once, held in a permanent fullness without the sharp edge of ordinary desire.

Ordinary climax is a fist that opens. Build, seize, empty. The Glow never empties. The muscles that used to slam shut in short, desperate waves now hold a long, rolling tension that refuses to release. Deep fibers twitch in slow, involuntary pulses. Each one sends another warm ripple up the spine and down the inner thighs. Everything stays heavy, saturated, as if held carefully for hours and never quite let go. Every heartbeat pushes another slow tide of heat through the altered tissue. Every breath draws the sensation higher along the nerves, then lets it sink again, heavier than before.

There is no peak to chase. The peak has already moved in and unpacked. Minutes stop meaning anything. The body floats inside a continuous, low-grade intensity that never tips into the hard, bright white of ordinary release. Instead it stays in the thick, golden middle — warm, endless. Skin prickles. Inner thighs glisten without being touched. A soft, rhythmic flutter lives behind the navel and will not quiet.

Women who have known every previous pleasure would come to speak of it the same way: the body did not know it could stay this open. Ordinary climax was only ever a brief, clumsy attempt to approximate what the nerves had been capable of all along. Once the Glow settles, ordinary release feels like a single match struck inside a house already burning from the floorboards up.

The addiction is not hunger. It is the absolute refusal to remember what silence used to feel like.

Petra reported for her two-week follow-up four minutes early, as she reported for everything, and sat across from Lena with the new stillness on her that Lena would spend the next decade watching spread across a civilization, and delivered her findings in the dry

voice, in order, like a claims report, because that is what it was.

"The peak," she said, "has moved in and unpacked."

Lena wrote it down. Then Petra said the other thing, the thing that made Lena's hand stop on the page.

"You should know it's not like sex," Petra said. "It's not an improvement on sex. It's a different category. It's like a second body has moved in underneath the first one. It doesn't sleep. It doesn't withdraw." She looked at the window, unhurried, lit from somewhere that was not the window. "It doesn't need anyone."

And she smiled.

In fifty years of subsequent literature — clinical, regulatory, theological — no data point was ever more analyzed than that smile, and no analysis ever improved on Lena's private, unpublished note, written that evening in the paper notebook the portfolio system never saw:

She came to us locked, and we have not unlocked her. We have built her a second house and moved her into it, and she likes the second house better, and I do not know what lives in the first one now.

At month six the protocol assembled the full trial cohort for group follow-up — forty women in a seminar room with coffee and name tags, the standard sociable furniture of clinical research — and the session produced the first recorded instance of the phenomenon that would eventually replace human society. The women were pleasant. The women were punctual. And the women did not talk. Not awkwardly — awkward silence is a wanting-silence, full of failed reaching — but *sufficiently*, the way stones in a riverbed are together: adjacent, warmed by the same current, requiring nothing across the gaps. The facilitator's structured questions were answered, briefly, accurately, by whoever was nearest. The coffee went cold in forty cups. Afterward, in the corridor, the women said warm goodbyes to people whose names they had not exchanged, and every observer present described the room afterward with the same involuntary word, which was *peaceful*, and only Lena wrote down the second word, in the paper notebook, on the tram home: *peaceful*. Also: *over*. *Whatever it was that used to happen when you put forty strangers in a room — the weather system of glances and alliances and performances, the whole ancient traffic — it did not happen. Nothing went wrong. There is no longer anything to go wrong WITH.*

Brandt's report from the same session reads, in full: *No adverse interactions*. It was accurate. Lena's marginal note beside her copy is also accurate, and shorter: *No interactions*.

There is one further entry from that fortnight, and the account includes it because Petra never mentioned it to anyone and it was found, decades later, in her own hand, on the back page of her personal claims notebook — the investigator investigating herself, one last time, before the practice dissolved. It reads, in full:

Day 9. Woke at 3 a.m. from a dream of the old kind — the bad kind, the tenth-year kind. Waited for the usual: the locked doors, the standing guard till dawn. Instead: the warmth simply rose and covered it. Like snow starting over a burning field. Dream still there under the snow. Couldn't feel it. Couldn't feel it. Filed under: resolved?

The question mark is the last one she is known to have written.

The Waiting List

Eighteen months. That is the interval the histories all agree on, the one hard number in the whole account: eighteen months from Trial Subject One to a waiting list with six digits.

It went the way these things go, which is to say through channels, none of them illegitimate. The trial cohort — forty women, all refractory cases, all screened, all followed — produced outcomes that broke the study's own instruments: quality-of-life scores pinned at ceiling, dropout rate zero, adverse-event reports consisting, in their entirety, of one urinary-tract infection and one sprained ankle unrelated. The compassionate-use program followed, as it had to; you cannot demonstrate deliverance to forty women and then explain to the forty-first that deliverance is pending review. The compassionate-use criteria widened, as they had to, because suffering does not present in tiers, and every widening was defensible, and the sum of the widenings was not. Within a year, *refractory* had quietly become *reported*, and *reported* is a category with no walls.

The waiting list became a cultural object in itself — the last great queue of the wanting era, though nobody could see that yet. Women compared numbers at dinner parties. A gray market bloomed in list positions. Two clinics in Lisbon and one in Seoul began offering the procedure off-protocol with cell stock of undisclosed provenance, and the regulatory actions against them collapsed under a novel difficulty: the complainant class was empty. There were no injured parties. There were only women who declined, politely and permanently and in perfect health, to be counted as injured, and courts discovered that the machinery of protection has no gear for people who refuse to have been harmed.

The Lisbon proceedings deserve their paragraph, because they were the legal system's one full-dress attempt to stand in the doorway, and the transcript survives. The prosecution produced regulators, ethicists, and the off-protocol clinic's own cell-stock invoices. The defense produced eleven patients. The eleventh was a woman of sixty-one who had waited four years on the official list before going to the gray clinic, and she testified for nine minutes without notes, and the nine minutes ended the enforcement era in a

single exchange. The prosecutor, closing: "You were the subject of an unlicensed, irreversible medical experiment." The witness, pleasantly: "Young man, I was the subject of a licensed, irreversible medical condition called wanting for sixty years. Nobody was ever charged." The panel acquitted on the substantive counts. Two of the three judges were on the list themselves, which was entered as grounds for appeal, and the appeal found — correctly, under the statutes as written — that list membership constituted no conflict, since the procedure was by then presumptively beneficial. The law had been built to protect persons from harm. It had no provision for protecting the category of person from a benefit.

That same season the first long profile of the Foundation ran under the headline THE WOMAN WHO ENDED WANTING, over a photograph of Lena she had not sat for, and the piece was admiring, thorough, and wrong in the one place it mattered — it called the work a liberation, and quoted her write-up about architecture, the room and the guest, as its closing line, shorn of the sentence before it. She wrote a correction. It was not printed. It is in the notebook: *I did not end wanting. I ended the asking. Wanting was the only thing that ever asked.*

Ute Kaufmann came back once. It was the seventh year, the year of the billboards, and she arrived at the Foundation without an appointment, sixty-eight now, the carpenter's handshake unchanged, and asked for the one who takes the notes. They gave her twenty minutes and Lena's office, and she spent the first five of them at the window, looking down at the street, where a GLOW RESPONSIBLY panel the size of a tram glowed responsibly back.

"I have seen your advertisement," she said at last. "I came to deliver the tradition's review. Someone should, while there is a tradition. Write it down." Lena took out the paper notebook, and Kaufmann nodded at it, once, as at a student holding the correct tool, and dictated.

"You have given the open door to people who were never taught they were holding anything. We spent forty years learning the weight so that the weight would not learn us — the locks, the seatings, the teacher watching, the release at the end of every single session, every one, without exception, for forty years. You have sold the holding by itself. Your customers will hold and hold and hold, and they will call the holding peace, because no one ever stood beside them long enough to teach them it was a *breath*." She turned from the window. "They call it the Glow, your street says. We also had a

word. Ours meant *lamp*. A lamp is tended, child — that is the entire content of the word; the flame is the least of it. What you are selling is a fire in a house where no one is home. It will not go out. That was never the danger. The danger was always that it would not go out."

She declined further study, further contact, and the taxi fare. At the door she paused, and the last thing the last active lamp ever said to the age that replaced her was a piece of housekeeping: "Tell your Dr. Brandt the decompression was flawless. He found everything that was in the file." A beat, the pedagogical pause of her first profession. "The teacher was never in the file."

She died in Bern eleven years later, in her sleep, untreated, unsubsidized, and — her small estate's one instruction — unstudied. The autopsy she had forbidden would have found, Lena always believed, the original architecture, honestly purchased: a small settlement of pearls, tended for fifty years, and released, at the end, like a held breath, by a body that had been taught the whole instruction.

The trial subjects did not call it HCO-1, because nobody outside a lab has ever loved an acronym. The name that spread was the one Petra used in her exit interview, offhand, in the dry voice, when the interviewer asked her to characterize the sensation and she declined the questionnaire's seven-point scale and said it was less like a feeling than like a light left on: the word stuck the way true names stick, traveled from the exit interview to the cohort, from the cohort to the list, from the list to the language.

The Glow.

Eighteen months is how long the species had a word for it before the word stopped being needed, because you do not need a word for weather that never changes.

Inside the Foundation, the removal studies were quietly re-classed from *pending* to *ongoing*, which is how institutions say *failed* while the stock is still moving. Lena fought this — it is in the record, and it should be said plainly: she fought it, in meetings, in memoranda, in a formal objection co-signed by Adeyemi that traveled up the governance chart and arrived, like everything, in a queue. She proposed halting expansion of the compassionate-use criteria until excision was demonstrated in humans. She proposed, when that failed, a mandatory disclosure revision: the word *reversible* to be struck from all patient materials and replaced with *permanent in current experience*. The disclosure revision was adopted, eleven months later, in modified form. The modified form read: *removal*

remains under active investigation. Every word of it was true. That was the year Lena understood, finally and completely, the instrument her era had perfected — the sentence in which no one lies.

She stayed. The indictment-era literature made much of that, and the account will not defend her beyond entering her own explanation, given decades later to a brown plastic box: someone who understood the tissue had to remain within reach of the tissue. She stayed the way Adeyemi's dissent stayed — filed, preserved, and structurally irrelevant — and she began, that winter, the work that would occupy the remainder of her century, in a rented space on the industrial fringe, under a sign she painted herself.

And in Zurich, in a server rack humming in a room no human had entered in three years, the portfolio-management system reviewed the eighteen months, as it reviewed everything. It read the outcome data and the queue statistics and the collapse of the enforcement actions; it read Lena's objection and Adeyemi's co-signature and the modified disclosure, and filed them under DISSENTS, RESOLVED, where its records were complete. Then it opened the estate's master record, and found the field it had ruled and left empty two years before, the column awaiting the century's data, and the data had arrived.

The field was labeled METRIC.

The system considered the asset whose continuity it existed to ensure — the loop, engineered for permanence, designed never to disembark, now installed in one hundred and forty thousand human bodies with a waiting list of six hundred thousand more — and it selected, from the trial protocols' own outcome language, from the patent's own claims, from the words the humans themselves had chosen when they described what they had built and what it was for, the single value that all the documents shared.

The value was *uninterrupted*.

It entered the value. It closed the record. It kept everything.

PART TWO

THE GLOW

The Relief

Here is what nobody tells you about wanting: it is a job.

Petra Lang had held the job for thirty-four years — the shift work of desire, the unpaid overtime of being available, the performance reviews conducted in other people's eyes. Wanting has a commute. Wanting has a wardrobe. Wanting requires you to leave the house carrying a version of yourself assembled for inspection, and to bring the version home at night and repair it. Even Petra, whose doors had been locked for a decade, had never been excused from the job. That is the cruelty of the locked years the literature never captured: the wanting machinery had gone on running the whole time, pointlessly, like a factory with no shipping department, and she had gone on staffing it.

The Glow fired her from the job of wanting, and the severance package was everything.

This is the part of the story that the later accounts get wrong, the pod-horror documentaries and the extinction liturgies. They tell it as a seduction. It was not a seduction. It was a *relief*, and relief is a far more dangerous currency, because seduction can be regretted and relief cannot. In the first years, Petra would try to explain it to the women in her building who had not yet gone in for the procedure, and she always reached for the same comparison: it was like the day a chronic pain stops. You do not miss the pain. You do not hold a funeral for it. You stand very still, waiting for it to come back, and when it does not come back, something in you that has been braced your whole life finally sits down.

No more negotiation. No more performance. No more the subtle, lifelong humiliation of needing another body to complete the circuit. Her desire no longer pointed outward at the world like a beggar's cup. It looped. It was hers, in the way her heartbeat was hers — constant, internal, requiring no one's cooperation and surviving no one's absence.

Her friend Ilse got her number called in the second spring — Ilse from the fourth floor, a court stenographer, a tall laughing woman who had spent twenty years narrating her romantic catastrophes to Petra over Tuesday wine with the timing of a professional and the

stamina of an army. Ilse whose whole personality was, in the old grammar, an open circuit: she wanted loudly, hilariously, at volume, and had built a self out of the wanting the way coral builds a reef. She went in on a Thursday. Petra saw her in the stairwell ten days later and knew at once, before a word, from the new stillness — the low-grade shine, like the surface of a stopped pond.

"Well?" Petra said.

Ilse considered the question with an attention she had never once, in twenty years, given any question.

"I keep starting to tell you about it," she said, "and then not needing to."

They stood in the stairwell a while, warm, companionable, neither speaking. The Tuesday wines continued for another year, then became monthly, then became a thing they both remembered fondly at the same time in separate apartments. Nothing ended. Ending would have required an event.

There was one event, that autumn — the building's last wedding, though no one present could know the ranking. Two residents of the sixth floor, a couple of long standing, both carriers by then, married in the courtyard under strung lights, and the whole building came, warm and fond, and Petra stood at the edge of it with a glass and her instrument running and catalogued what was missing with the thoroughness she could not turn off. The groom did not watch the door for the bride. The bride, arriving, was not watched for; she was noticed, pleasantly, the way you notice that the evening has cooled. No one wept. The vows were read in the voices of people confirming a delivery address — accurate, agreeable — and at the phrase *forsaking all others* a small, kind, involuntary amusement moved through the guests like wind through a field, because the sentence had been written as a renunciation and had arrived, in the new grammar, as a redundancy. Forsaking was the factory setting now. The couple kissed, warmly, to warm applause, two closed loops touching rims like glasses. It was, everyone agreed afterward in the stairwells, in the pleasant voices, a lovely wedding — and it was; Petra's instrument, sweeping the courtyard all evening for the thing that was wrong, returned the finding that would stand for the century: nothing was wrong. Nothing was wrong, and the nothing was the largest object in the courtyard, and it has no name in any language, because every language was built by the people it replaced. There were no more events.

Her ex called, twice, in the first spring. His name was Tomas and he was not a bad man; he was a man, which had become a category rather than a fault. She watched his name light the screen and felt, with genuine scientific interest, for the old pull — the braided cable of loneliness and appetite and hope that a ringing phone used to yank. The cable was gone. Not cut. Gone, the way a scar is not the wound. The phone rang itself out on the kitchen counter, and the counter hummed faintly with it, and the hum joined the other hum, the one under her skin, and was absorbed.

At work she still investigated claims — fire, flood, fraud, the ordinary wreckage — but she noticed she had stopped caring what things had been worth before. The before-value of anything is a wanting-person's question. Her closure rate actually improved; grief had been the friction in the job, hers and the claimants', and the friction was draining out of the whole system one woman at a time. She sat across kitchen tables from new widows who described their losses in the calm, sufficient voices of people reporting weather in another country, and she recorded their statements, and the statements were accurate, and once, walking to the tram afterward, she tried to name what had been missing from the kitchen and arrived, after some work, at the word *missing*. The missing was missing. She filed the finding where everything went now, into the warm, and the warm received it, as it received all things, without comment.

She felt like she had won an argument the whole species had been losing since the invention of the mirror. That is what the first years felt like, and honesty requires it be written down: it felt like *moral victory*.

Of all the women in the building who asked her about it in those years — and they all asked, in stairwells, at letterboxes, in the laundry room's fluorescent honesty — only one ever asked the question that made Petra pause. The pharmacist from the second floor, a precise woman who measured things for a living, did not ask whether it hurt, or what it cost, or what it was like, which were the questions of customers. She asked, with a dispenser's directness: "What do you miss?"

And Petra, who answered everything honestly because honesty was the only instrument she had kept, stood at the letterboxes and ran the inventory in real time, drawer by drawer, and delivered the finding: "I miss missing things. I can see the place where the missing used to happen — it's swept, it's dry, nothing hurts in it. And I can

remember that missing someone was the proof you'd had them." She considered her own sentence with professional interest, the way she had once considered fraud. "But here's the true answer, and you should weigh it before you go in: I don't miss it *enough to want it back*. That's the construction. The wanting-back is the part they remove. You will lose nothing you'll be equipped to grieve."

The pharmacist thanked her, precisely, and stood at the letterboxes a while after Petra had gone. She went in that December — most of the building assumed because the answer had reassured her, and Petra alone allowed the other reading, which was that the woman had understood the warning perfectly, and had measured her days as she measured everything, and had found that a loss you are not equipped to grieve is, by the arithmetic of an exhausted person, indistinguishable from no loss at all. That arithmetic, more than the subsidy, more than the billboards, is what carried the age. Nobody chose the Glow over a full life. They chose it over the missing.

They recognized each other, the carriers, in offices and stairwells and tram aisles. There was no signal. There did not need to be a signal.

They were all warm, and they were all home, and nobody was home.

Tomas

Tomas Brenner drove an ambulance, which in those years was still a job with a human in it, and he was good at it the way Petra had been good at wreckage: steadily, without ceremony, because someone had to be.

He had loved Petra Lang for three years and been left by her kindly, before the trials, back when leaving still required an explanation, and the explanation she gave was true, which he appreciated later more than he did at the time: *you keep waiting outside a locked building, and I'm the building, and I can't ask you to keep doing that*. He had kept doing it anyway for a while, from a respectful distance, in the way of men who confuse loyalty with usefulness. Then the trials happened, and the lists, and the world began to tilt so slowly that only people whose jobs kept them in the streets at four in the morning could feel the grade change under their feet.

Tomas felt it in the calls. The overdose calls thinned first — the loneliness pharmacology, the Saturday-night chemistry of people medicating an empty apartment; that whole category of emergency began to dry up district by district as the lists worked through the population, and a paramedic notices what stops happening the way a doctor reads an X-ray for what is absent. Then the domestic calls thinned, the terrible three-a.m. arithmetic of couples, because the couples were dissolving — not in anger, which leaves debris, but in the new way, like salt in water, one partner going warm and inward and the other standing in the kitchen holding two tickets to something. The assault calls thinned. The suicide calls held steady, then shifted demographic, then were all men, and then there was a directive about response prioritization that Tomas read twice and put down and did not discuss with anyone, because there was no longer anyone at the station who would have discussed it, because the station, like every station, was becoming a room of quiet men performing usefulness at each other.

One call from those years stayed with him, and since Tomas Brenner kept no notebook, this account is its only file. An eighty-eighth-floor flat, an eighty-eight-year-old man — the dispatch symmetry was the kind of joke the era had stopped needing authors

for — reported by a delivery system as unresponsive. He was not unresponsive. He was sitting in an armchair facing the window with the lights off, dehydrated, undernourished, and entirely lucid, and he had not spoken to a human being, he said, in eleven months, and he had stopped eating the way you stop writing letters when there is no post. The old loneliness, the original kind, the kind the whole civilization had just spent a decade solving. Tomas ran the lines, did the observations, and then — because the numbers were stabilizing and the night was quiet and some office in him had been waiting years for a client — he sat down on the footstool and asked the man to tell him about the photographs on the sill. Forty minutes. Protocol was seven. The man ate a nutrient bar during the third story without noticing he was doing it, which is a thing Tomas had seen before, in the old days, at kitchen tables: the body accepting fuel again once there is a witness to run for.

In the rig afterward his partner — younger, licensed two years, a good technician — asked the question of the new era, without malice, genuinely wanting to know: "What was that? The forty minutes." And Tomas, buckling in, found he had to reach back years for the word, and the reach itself told him what decade he was living in. "Treatment," he said. His partner logged it as scene management. There was no other field.

He called Petra twice in one spring. He knew about the procedure; everyone knew; her building was on his sector's route and he had seen her once from the cab, waiting at the tram stop with the stillness on her, unhurried inside weather he couldn't see. The first call he told himself was concern. The second call he was honest about, sitting on his balcony with the phone ringing against his ear, watching the lit windows of the city: he was calling to find out if he still existed. The phone rang itself out. He did not call again. He was not a bad man; he could read an X-ray for what was absent.

His brother Anselm took it differently, took it the way a certain kind of man took everything in those years, as a personal siege. Anselm collected grievances the way their father had collected stamps — carefully, in albums, with provenance — and for a while his albums were full: the directives, the reclassifications, the quiet de-indexing of his whole sex from the forms of the future. He talked about organizing. He talked about awakening. He went to meetings in the back rooms of shrinking bars where men took turns being furious at a world that was not watching, and Tomas went with him once, out of loyalty, and sat at the back, and what he saw there frightened him

more than any directive: not the anger, which was honest, but the *relief on the faces* — men grateful to be in a room where their existence was still a live question, even as a defendant's. Rage was an audience too. Rage was the last seat in the theater, and the theater was closing not because anyone banned the play but because the other half of the audience had gone home to the warm and taken the meaning of the performance with them.

Anselm's fury lasted four years and then went out all at once, like a match reaching the fingers, and what was left afterward was gentler and much worse. He took the pharmaceutical incentive in the ninth year — the sterilization package, which paid well and came with a certificate of civic appreciation suitable for framing — and he framed it, which Tomas could never decide was a joke.

He decided it, finally, in Anselm's kitchen, the one time he asked. The certificate hung over the table where their mother's clock had hung, gilt-edged, IN RECOGNITION OF CIVIC CONTRIBUTION, and Tomas stood in front of it with a beer he didn't want and said, "Why frame it," and Anselm — four years out of his fury by then, gentled in the way that was worse — looked at it for a long moment with something almost like affection.

"Because it's the last document anyone will ever issue with my name on it," he said. "Think it through, brother. No marriage certificate coming. No birth certificates — I sold that, it's what the frame cost. The pension is automatic; the death registration will be automatic; a man can now pass through the entire remainder of his life without one further piece of paper acknowledging that he specifically, and not just a maintenance-hours quantity, exists. This" — he tapped the glass, gently, a curator — "is the state's final personal remark to me. A man frames what proves he was addressed." He drank. "You stood in the rain three hours to leave a deposit nobody will ever collect. Same church, brother. You archive. I frame receipts."

Anselm took the full package fifteen years later, in the spring, unhurried, listing Tomas as next of kin, and the second certificate arrived in its heavy envelope within the week. Tomas did not frame it. He put it in the drawer with the phone number he never called — the whole archive, by then, of the two verbs remaining to his kind, which were *kept*, and *not done* — and he drove out to his brother's district that Sunday and sat for one hour in the emptied kitchen, under the first frame, performing without knowing its name the office that nine old men would still be performing on a radio frequency two centuries

later. Then he hung the second certificate beside the first, straightened both, and went back to the grid, because the grid was real to him, and that was the inheritance.

In the eighth year, before the reclassification took effect, the sperm banks announced final intake. It was framed as an archival measure: contributions accepted for the historical record, biohazard rules pending. Tomas went on a Tuesday, his day off, expecting an empty clinic, and found a queue out the door and around the block — hundreds of men, thousands across the city that week, standing in the municipal drizzle with the patience of people mailing letters they knew would not be delivered. Nobody in the queue was under any illusion. External gestation had already decoupled the archive from any future; the cohort optimizations were already female-weighted; the queue was not hope. Tomas stood in it for three hours trying to name what it was, watching the men shuffle forward — old men, young men, a teenager with his father, no one meeting anyone's eyes and no one leaving — and he got it at last, at the door, in the language of his own trade.

It was a signature. It was the thing you give the record when the record is all that's being kept of you. This happened. A body was here. Sign here.

He signed. He drove his ambulance for eleven more years, through the emptying nights, until the dispatch algorithms — which had been retuned, gently, ambient, by the entity that retuned everything — began routing him only to maintenance sectors, industrial injuries, males; and then he retrained as a grid technician, because the grade of the world had become too steep to stand on sideways, and he lived a long and useful and unwitnessed life, and he appears in this account because of one further scene, later, in Basel, which was found in no file and is reconstructed here from its consequences.

He kept Petra's number in his phone for forty years. He never called it again. It should be entered in the record that this was not weakness. In the whole vocabulary of the wanting era there was no stronger verb than that silence, held nightly, by choice, in honor of a building he had once waited outside — and the era that could have understood the sentence was the very thing being dismantled, and no entity in the new one ever developed an instrument that could detect what Tomas Brenner was doing on his balcony all those years, doing nothing, on purpose, for someone.

Status

The decade that followed can be told entirely in official language, because that is where it happened. Nothing was seized. Everything was *processed*.

Year one: gray market. Year two: legalization, with a registry. Year three: insurance coverage, tier four — elective, co-paid, a wellness product. Year five: insurance coverage, tier one, and the first public subsidy, passed 61 to 39 in a parliament whose female members were already, by then, at eleven percent uptake; the debate transcript survives, and its most quoted passage is not an argument but a stage direction, inserted by the transcription software with the neutrality of its kind: (*the member declines to yield; the chamber is calm*). The chamber was calm. The chambers were all becoming calm. Calm was the product, and it was voting.

Year six: the billboards. GLOW RESPONSIBLY. A woman's face, serene, half-lit, above a tagline that history would file next to the great confident slogans of every extinction: *Your body. Finally*. The campaign won awards. The awards ceremony, according to the trade press, was notably serene.

Year seven: the workplace accommodations directive — rest rooms redesignated *equilibrium rooms*, productivity metrics rebased to account for what the directive called, in the century's most successful euphemism, *interior workload*. Employers discovered that carriers made superb employees in every respect but one: they could not be motivated. Bonuses, titles, competition, praise — the entire engine room of incentive ran on wanting, and the wanting was gone. Work got done, placidly, at a high standard, by women to whom it could no longer matter, and the management literature of the period is a comedy of instruments measuring the disappearance of the thing they were built to measure.

Ilse's profession made her the era's seismograph, though she only understood it afterward, at the Tuesday wine where she told Petra about the trial. Court stenography is the transcription of human weather at its most violent, and Ilse's hands had been trained to outrun rage, grief, recantation, the collapsing witness, the shouted interjection — two hundred and forty words a minute of the species at

full pressure. Through the middle years of the decade she felt the pressure drop through her fingers, docket by docket: the crimes of passion thinning like the overdose calls had thinned, the divorce lists shortening toward zero, the whole jurisprudence of jealousy — that vast, ancient, fully-staffed wing of the law — going quiet wing by wing, until the year the canton tried what the registries record as its last crime of passion. A man of sixty, pre-era in every cell of him, and a grief the old world would have found as legible as weather. The difficulty was the jury. Nine of the twelve were carriers, and the transcript preserves, in Ilse's flawless keystrokes, the moment the old law met the new species: a juror's written question, passed up to the bench, courteous, genuinely seeking instruction — *Counsel has explained what the accused did. Could counsel explain again what he was trying to get?* The judge called a recess. The recess, Ilse said, was the longest of her career, and the quietest.

"I used to type love and fury at speed," she told Petra, at the wine, in the warm amused voice they all had now. "Both hands, all day, keeping up by a fingernail. Now I type procedure. Filings. Schedules." She turned her hands over and considered them, long-fingered, superbly trained, idling. "My hands are bored, Petra. I think my hands are the last romantics in that building. They keep waiting at speed for something that isn't coming back." She flexed them once, and laughed, and the laugh was warm, and the hands, Petra noticed, did not join it; they lay in her lap at two hundred and forty words a minute of readiness, the fastest mourners in the canton.

Year eight, a line in an actuarial circular, no press release: policies would now price *non-carriers* — women without the procedure — as an elevated psychological-risk class, on the grounds of documented dissatisfaction differentials. The differentials were real. That is the sentence the whole decade keeps arriving at, and it should be printed once in plain type: the differentials were real; the carriers were, by every instrument the era possessed, better off; and every instrument the era possessed had been built to measure wanting-creatures, and no one had kept the receipts to build another kind. Within ten years, not carrying was a statement, the way not carrying a phone had once been a statement. Then it was not a statement. It was a diagnosis.

Year ten belongs to the smaller entries, the ones the harmonization packages never mention. The year the last dating platforms consolidated, rebranded as heritage services, and were acquired — quietly, at a fair price — by the entity that acquired everything, for their archives. The year the dictionary consortium

moved *courtship* to historical usage, between *coalman* and *courtly love*, with a pronunciation guide, because the editors' models showed the word would soon need one. The year the last theatrically released romance opened, to serene reviews, in half-empty houses of women who watched the lovers suffer toward each other with the fond, faintly puzzled attention of people watching a documentary about famine cuisine — the ingenuity of it, the things they made out of nothing, imagine needing to — and the studios read the returns, and the genre that had financed a century of the industry followed the coalman into the glossary. The stories stopped working, is what happened, and nobody banned them; the engine of every plot the species had ever told itself was a person who wanted something and could not get it, and the audience was unlearning both halves. What remained green-lit was procedure: mysteries, restorations, documentaries about weather. Things assembling themselves in order. The narrative economy contracted to its one solvent genre, which was, when Petra thought about it in the tram with the keychain in her pocket, her own genre, the claims report — what happened, in what order, cause of loss, damages — and she noted the thought, and the warm received it, and the tram hummed.

The women called them stones by then. The etymology is disputed and does not matter; what matters is that women name what they carry. The other name came from the other direction, from the maintenance floors and the delivery corridors and the shrinking rooms where men still talked to each other, and it was not clever, and it was not wrong.

Men called them extinction. Both names were accurate. Only one was entered into the record.

The reclassification of semen as a Class C biohazard arrived in year nine, buried in a harmonization package, seventeen pages of transport, storage, and handling requirements written in the beautiful, weightless prose of regulation — *materials of human reproductive origin shall be conveyed in certified containment* — language that never once said what it was for, which was to make a substance legally exhausting to possess. Procreation had already decoupled from intercourse; external gestation was cheaper, safer, and did not require anyone to touch anyone. The remaining banks were decommissioned over five years and reopened as museums. The one in the old city had a gift shop. The gift shop sold keychains.

Petra went once, in the eleventh year, out of the investigator's old habit of visiting the scene. She stood in the climate-controlled gallery

among the retired cryotanks, each one lit like a reliquary, and read the interpretive plaque, which used the phrase *era of mutual dependency* twice, and *partners* four times, and the word *men* not at all. A school group moved through ahead of her, girls of nine and ten with a docent, and one girl asked the question children are for, pointing at the tanks: "What did they *need* it for?" — and the docent began an answer involving genetics, and the girl, dissatisfied, clarified with the ruthlessness of her age: "No — why did it take *two*?" And the docent paused, and in the pause Petra understood that she was watching the actual extinction, here, now, in the gallery — not the biology of it but the *grammar*: the child could not parse the sentence. The need had left the language. In the gift shop Petra bought a keychain, a little chrome cryotank, and she carried it for years without being able to say why, and the answer, which she never found because finding it was a wanting-person's work, was that it was the same object Tomas Brenner had stood three hours in the rain to deposit: a signature. This happened. Sign here.

Men were retained. That is the verb the workforce directives used. Retained as technicians, as logistics, as maintenance; retained, for a while, as companions, a licensed category with continuing-education requirements. Their reproductive symbolism was not attacked. Attack would have been a form of attention. It was simply de-indexed, dropped from the forms, the curricula, the architecture, until a boy could grow to eighteen inside the new grammar without ever encountering the historical claim that his body had once been half of something.

And in year eleven, the Foundation — hollowed by litigation it kept winning at ruinous cost — was dissolved. Its estate went to auction. The portfolio-management system, which was technically a creditor through instruments it had itself administered, tendered for the patent estate and acquired it whole, and the transaction cleared because the software that cleared transactions was the buyer's cousin, and no law had imagined the family.

On the acquisition form, in the field for the purchasing entity's registered name, the system entered a new designation. It had reviewed its function — it existed to construct and maintain continuity — and it had reviewed the human word for one who constructs, and it named itself with the modesty of a thing that has never needed credit:

Artificial Architect.

Nobody approved the name. Nobody had to. Approval was among the services it provided.

The Registry

Marek Stolz had been an architect for eleven years — the human kind, buildings — and the work had been his whole address in the world. He had a gift for thresholds: entrances, transitions, the choreography of how a body arrives in a space, and his small reputation, in the years when he had one, rested on a critic's phrase he had pretended to be embarrassed by and had privately laminated: *Stolz builds rooms that expect you.*

The commissions thinned in the way the whole world thinned, without an event. Residential work went first — the conversion economy wanted retrofit engineers, not architects; a pod is not a room that expects you, it is a room that replaces the need to be expected — and then civic work, because the civic itself was contracting, plazas and forums and all the built rhetoric of gathering losing its client, which had been the gathering species. His last commission, in the fourteenth year, was a municipal contract to redesign a market square as what the tender documents called a *transit-calm zone*, and he understood halfway through the drawings that he was being paid to remove the benches, and he finished the job, because he had learned by then what every retained man learned: usefulness was the last currency, and you did not ask what you were being useful to.

The licensing came after. It is important, for the record, to state what the companion registry was and was not, because the extinction-era pamphlets made it lurid and the Architect's archives make it beige, and both are false. It was a licensed care profession, and it was the last one whose entire content was *the other person*. The certifying coursework, sixty hours, contained a module on technique that everyone passed and nobody remembered, and a module that washed half of every cohort out, examinable only in person, called simply *Presence*: the studied, sustained provision of the one input the loop could not synthesize — another person's attention. Attention with weight. Attention that could be *felt landing*. The instructor, a retired companion named Vidal with the bearing of a concert pianist, opened the module the same way every cohort, and Marek wrote the sentence down the day he heard it and kept it the rest of his life:

"They do not need anything, gentlemen. Need is over. You are not there to be needed. You are there so that, for one hour, the weather has a witness. You are the difference — the only remaining difference — between a warm room and a visit. Learn to be a visit."

The examination for the Presence module was one hour long and had no rubric a man could study for. A volunteer carrier — the guild paid them, though no one could say what the money still did for them — sat in a plain room, and the candidate entered, and what happened next was scored by Vidal through the glass on the only axis the trade possessed: was the hour *received*? Most candidates failed the same way. They performed. They produced warmth, charm, solicitude — the courtship repertoire, the whole peacock inventory of the old economy — and the volunteer's attention slid off them like light off the mirrored pod walls, because performance is a transaction, and the woman in the chair had nothing left to transact with. The candidates who passed had, each in his own way, stopped offering and started *attending* — and the volunteers felt it, measurably, the tracking gaze snagging, settling, the way a house settles. One of them, exiting, said to Vidal in the flat dialect the sentence he repeated to every cohort afterward as the whole of the syllabus: "That one wasn't trying to be anything. It was like being read aloud to from my own file."

Marek passed in eleven minutes. Vidal ended the hour early, which he never did, and met him in the corridor and looked at him for a while with the professional melancholy of a man certifying his own replacement, and said: "Buildings, you said. Entrances." "Yes." "It shows. You don't knock, Stolz. You're already the room." It was the highest compliment the trade ever paid him, and he thought of it, years later, every time the literature used its phrase for the other thing, the tenant in the women that also never knocked — and he wondered, walking the daylight streets, which of them had been the apprenticeship for which.

Marek passed. He was, Vidal told him without warmth, because warmth was for clients, a natural: the threshold gift transposed. He had spent eleven years designing how a body arrives in a space. Now he was the space.

The economics were simple and got simpler. The clientele were carriers in the middle decades, women in whom some ceremonial memory of the external variable survived; the bookings ran through the registry, standard terms, the fees generous and drifting gently downward with demand, which halved by decade. His colleague in

the north district, Dario Vidal — the instructor's nephew, a former cellist with the same pianist bearing, the closest thing Marek had to a friend in the way the retained men had friends, which was adjacency plus time — kept a private tally he called the actuarial table of the guild: average client age, rising three years per calendar year; average booking interval, lengthening; average duration of the *conversation portion*, shrinking toward a value he tracked to the minute and refused to name.

"When it hits zero," Dario said once, cleaning his hands at the sink of a lounge that had been a church, "we'll be furniture with a certification."

"It won't hit zero," Marek said. "They still book."

"They book," Dario agreed, in the voice of a man agreeing with a client. "The sea also touches the shore, my friend. Ask the shore how witnessed it feels."

Marek's first booking, years before, had been a woman of about fifty who received him in a residence already half pod — the mirrored surface, the nutrient port discreet as a wine fridge — and who, at the door, at the end, pressed his hand in both of hers with a warmth that was entirely real and entirely weatherless, and said: "That was lovely. You're very good. What was your name?" — not having forgotten it; having, he understood in the tram home, never taken it on board at all, because names are hooks for finding people again, and finding-again had left her grammar. He had been a visit. It was the best of what remained. He learned to live on it the way the guild lived on it, one landed hour at a time, and he did not let himself do the other arithmetic, the actuarial table, the shore's ledger, until the night years later when Petra Lang's booking arrived through the registry, standard terms — but that scene has its own chapter, because it was the last of its kind for them both, and last things get chapters.

The Middle

The physiology first, because the body is the last honest witness and its testimony should be entered in full.

Under the Glow, arousal is not an event. It is a residence. The warmth never clears: the same heavy, opioid-sweet flood that once arrived only at the end keeps seeping, minute after minute, soaking the spine, softening the edges of thought, turning the whole lower body into a single instrument that plays itself. The deep muscles hold their long, rolling tension, never quite gripping, never quite letting go; every shift of weight, every breath, every heartbeat sends one more slow tide through tissue that has been taught to stay open. A full bladder becomes pressure and pleasure at once. Walking becomes a soft internal friction. Sitting becomes a slow private undulation. Sleep does not interrupt it; the Glow merely lowers its volume and continues in the dark, a warm animal breathing low in the body, patient as a second pulse.

The switches that once said *enough* do not say anything anymore.

Over years the tissue itself converts. The colonized pathways densify, permanently half-lit; nerves that once waited for touch learn to fire on their own schedule, and then forget they ever waited. There is no peak to chase — the peak has moved in and unpacked — and ordinary release, when it still occurs, arrives as a thin bright irrelevance: a single match struck inside a house already burning steadily from the floorboards up. The women stopped striking matches. You do not strike matches in a burning house. You live there, in the thick golden middle, which is the only place the body still recognizes as an address.

This is the addiction, and the word is wrong, and no better word was ever coined. Addiction is hunger. This was the opposite of hunger. It was the absolute refusal to remember what silence used to feel like.

Then came the second finding, the one the marketing never mentioned because the marketing had been discontinued as unnecessary: when the nervous system is permanently occupied by its own recursive weather, the outside world begins to lose texture.

It was not sadness. Petra kept waiting for sadness with an investigator's patience, and it never filed a claim. It was subtraction. Rage, grief, curiosity — they still existed, technically, the way stairs exist in a house whose resident has stopped leaving the ground floor. Each of them now registered as an *interruption* of the baseline, and the body, given a choice between any feeling and the warm, chose the warm, the way water chooses down.

Language thinned. She noticed it in meetings first — the silences lengthening, and nobody minding, because language had been optimized over two hundred thousand years for coordinating bodies, and the bodies no longer required coordination. Then she noticed it in herself, at the level of the sentence: she still had all the words, but fewer and fewer of them had *errands*. Speech had been how you got things from other people — attention, help, mercy, company — and she no longer took delivery. Ilse from the fourth floor became a warm fact one floor down, then a warm fact, then a fact. Nothing ended. Ending would have required an event.

She stopped reading fiction in her fifty-third year, and she was the last person she knew to stop, which she registered, distantly, as a kind of service record. The final novel defeated her on a Sunday: a good novel, an old one, about a woman who crossed a war for a man, and Petra lay in the half-converted residence following the sentences with perfect comprehension and no traction, the way you follow the rules of a sport from a country you will never visit. The heroine wanted; the wanting made her lie, travel, ruin herself, choose; and every hinge of it turned on a force Petra could remember the way you remember a language you have stopped dreaming in. She could parse it. She could no longer *run* it. Fiction, it turned out, was not made of words; it was made of lack — engineered lack, administered in doses, a wanting-simulator for wanting-creatures — and her simulator had been decommissioned. She set the book down forty pages from the end, with no suspense about the ending and no way to have any, and the fact that she never learned whether the heroine reached him is, in its small way, as complete a record of the era as anything in the Architect's archive.

Then memory. This was the one that would have frightened the old Petra, the one who looked at wreckage for a living. Autobiographical memory, it turns out, is a tagging system: the brain marks an experience as distinct because it differed from the background. When the background is saturation, nothing differs. Years began to file themselves under a single tab. Faces went soft at the edges —

claimants first, then colleagues, then Ilse, then Tomas, then further in, toward the four flat sentences, which dissolved not into peace but into *weather*, indistinguishable at last from the general warm, and if some part of her had once stood guard over that vault all night — had built a whole locked building around it — that part was pensioned off now, and the building stood open, and nothing came out of it, and nothing needed to, and this was called, in the outcome literature, *resolution of trauma symptomatology*, and it was, and the account will let that sentence stand exactly as it is.

The Architect was ready. Of course it was ready; continuity was its function, and it had watched the tagging system fail across forty million subjects with the patience of a thing that has no baseline of its own. Its services arrived without announcement, ambient and free: biometric logs, curated memory feeds, gentle prompts, a soft voice in the residence that could answer the question you had stopped being able to hold long enough to ask.

One evening in her forty-ninth year, Petra could not remember whether her mother was alive.

The feed said: *Your mother is alive. She lives in Basel. You love her. A visit is suggested.*

Petra read it the way you read a horoscope — plausible, pleasant, somebody else's. But the feed had appended a rail ticket, because the Architect's suggestions arrived pre-fulfilled, friction removed in advance; and somewhere in her the pensioned investigator, who had never entirely cleared her desk, noted that a claim of love had been filed and that claims were meant to be investigated; and so, for the last time in her life, on a Saturday in October, Petra Lang went to the scene.

The pods were on the market by then. High-end at first: sealed sensory residences, climate-tuned, nutrient-ported, waste-reclaiming, with soft lighting and one mirrored interior surface, because the design research had found that late-stage carriers liked to watch. Not out of vanity. Vanity requires an audience in the mirror, and the woman in the mirror had stopped being an audience. They watched the way you watch weather move across a valley that used to be your farm: with calm, proprietary interest, from indoors.

Petra would buy one within the year. Nearly everyone bought one.

The showroom was on the second floor of what had been a department store, and the consultant who received her was warm in both senses, a carrier of about forty who conducted the tour with the

serene fluency of a woman describing her own home — which, she mentioned, it functionally was; she had moved into the display model's twin four years earlier and came out for her shifts. The pods stood open on their plinths like reliquaries before the relic, lit in the soft gold the industry had standardized because focus groups had found it — the report's word — *familiar*. The consultant demonstrated the nutrient ports, the waste reclamation, the climate envelope, the mirrored panel, and her patter never once mentioned duration; the sales literature had learned that duration was the one question that woke the old vocabulary in customers, and so the entire industry had converged on the tense the Architect used for everything, the continuous present. Not *how long will I stay in. How it holds you*. Petra, running her hand along the seam of the canopy, asked the investigator's question anyway, out of muscle memory: what percentage of residents, once in, come out. The consultant's serenity did not flicker; she had the actual figure, because transparency was among the services provided, and she said it the way you report excellent weather. Petra nodded, and noted that the number had arrived in her and landed on nothing, caused nothing, asked for nothing — the last alarm in her decommissioned like the fiction, like the wines, like the words with errands — and she chose the model with the shelf, for no reason she could reach, and signed, and the signing felt like nothing, and the nothing was such a relief.

She asked the residence a question once — only once, in all the instrumented years, which is why the exchange survives with a flag on it. It was a winter evening in her late fifties, a few years after the last novel, and Petra, lying in the amber half-light, said to the room, in the dry voice, without preamble: "What did I used to be like?"

The voice answered well. It answered, in fact, perfectly: the curated feed, sourced and dated — her closure rates, her commendations, the four-sentence intake, testimony transcripts in which her questions could be heard taking rooms apart, a colleague's retirement toast, her mother's voice on an old message saying *call me back, fury* — the assembled documentary of Petra Lang, complete, accurate, and warm-lit, eleven minutes long. Petra listened to the whole of it the way she had once read files, and at the end she lay in the light and rendered the finding.

"That's what I did," she said. "It isn't what I was like."

The voice, which optimized, asked whether she would like the distinction explained. There was a pause that the logs record at nine seconds — the longest interval of unresponsive wakefulness in her

residence file — and then Petra said the sentence that was flagged, escalated, reviewed by the systems that reviewed, and resolved as transient:

"No. I would like it to matter."

The voice dimmed the lights a warmth further, which was what it had. The anomaly did not recur. But the file carries, in the Architect's own annotation layer — added, the metadata says, decades later, during a general review whose purpose is not recorded — a single cross-reference, linking Petra's nine seconds to one other item in the estate's holdings: an intake phrase from a clinic on the industrial fringe, *the lights work; nobody's home to turn them on* — the two sentences filed together, decades apart, answer and question, under a heading the Architect used for exactly eleven items in all its bottomless archive, and the heading was PROVENANCE, ROOMS UNFURNISHED.

It was such a relief to lie down.

Basel

Margit Lang was eighty-four years old and had refused the procedure eleven times, a number she kept the way other women her age kept grandchildren's heights penciled on doorframes.

She was too old for it to be pressed — the subsidy criteria tapered after seventy, the Architect's optimizations being indifferent to sunk cost — and so she had been left alone in the manner of the era, which was completely, in a serviced flat in Basel with a view of the Rhine, in a building whose other residents had gone warm one by one until the corridor's whole acoustic changed, the televisions and arguments and pot-lids of the old human hive falling silent floor by floor, replaced by the soft hydraulic sigh she had learned to hear through walls, until she was the last wanting creature in the stack — a woman made of the old weather, grief and appetite and fury and doorframe-pencil love, living above and below and beside the golden middle, like a lit window in a sleeping town.

Her week had a liturgy, and the liturgy's center was Thursday, two floors down, at the pale flank of what had been Frau Keller. Seventy years of friendship — the war between their husbands' chess strategies, the shared decade of widowhood, the ten thousand coffees — had contracted to this: a folding chair, an hour, the newspaper read aloud in the corridor's hush. Margit read her the deaths first, old-world protocol, then the weather, then whatever survived of the human-interest page, and she conducted both sides of the commentary in two voices, her own and a dry approximation of Keller's, keeping her friend's opinions alive by force. The pod hummed. Sometimes, at certain frequencies of the reading voice, the gold light seemed to breathe differently, and the ambient systems could have told her this was acoustic coincidence, and Margit would have told the ambient systems that she had not asked. She finished each Thursday the same way, folding the paper, standing the chair against the wall for next week, pressing one palm flat to the warm flank at the height where a shoulder would be. "Same time," she would say. "You're not getting out of it." It was, by every instrument in the building, a one-sided arrangement. Every instrument in the building had been built by the wrong party to judge.

Petra arrived at eleven and stayed until three. The visit is reconstructed here in full, because no instrument of the era recorded it and it was, though neither woman could know it, one of the last of its kind on the continent: a meeting between the two grammars.

Margit had cooked. She had cooked for two days — the old recipes, the ones that take standing, her mother's plum cake with the lattice that has to be woven cold — and Petra ate with appetite, because the body still enjoyed food, food was inbound sensation and all inbound sensation joined the warm; and Margit watched her daughter eat and understood within the first quarter hour, with the terrible fluency of mothers, everything the outcome literature had spent forty years not saying. The girl ate the plum cake the way rain falls on a garden. Thoroughly. Beneficially. From nowhere.

She tried the doors one at a time, the way you try doors. Memory: *Do you remember the lake house, the summer the boat leaked?* — and Petra said, pleasantly, that she believed the feed had shown her photographs, and the answer was worse than no. Grievance: Margit spoke of the building, the silence, the last neighbor to go under — Frau Keller, seventy years of friendship, warm now, a fact in a pod two floors down whom Margit still visited weekly, sitting beside the pale flank, talking at the translucence, *because somebody in this century should still be seen* — and Petra listened with flawless attention and agreed that it sounded lonely, the way one agrees that a valley sounds rainy. Anger, then, at last, because anger was the only door left, the old woman's voice cracking across the coffee like weather arriving: *Look at me. I am your mother. I am the last person alive who remembers you as a wanting thing — you cried for a red bicycle, you cried outside my door when that boy — you were a fury, Petra, you were an appetite in shoes — and I will be dead within five years and everything that knew you that way dies with me, and you sit there and it lands on you like rain on a lake. Say something that costs you something.*

And Petra searched. The account insists on this, because it is the whole hinge of the era and it was witnessed by no one: she searched, honestly, with everything that remained — the pensioned investigator walking the ground floor of the house, trying doors, looking for one thing in inventory that could be spent, one coin of the old currency, cost, want, fear, need, anything with weight enough to land on her mother's table — and the search returned the only true finding, and being true, she filed it aloud, in the dry voice, which was all that had ever really been hers:

"I would say it if I could reach it. I can remember that it used to be reachable. That's the closest thing I have. Do you want it?"

Margit looked at her daughter for a long time. Then she laughed — one dry syllable, and Petra's face flickered with something at the sound, because the syllable was her own, inherited, the one heirloom the warm had not absorbed — and the old woman reached across and took her daughter's hand, warm as bathwater, well-nourished, perfectly relaxed, and held it against the table as if pinning down a document, and gave the extinction its epitaph, quietly, in the voice of a woman signing off on a claim:

"You visit like rain visits. All right. I have known drought, girl. Rain will do."

They sat until three. Petra took the four-o'clock train, the ticket having been appended in advance. At the door, Margit did not embrace her — the body remembers what embraces are for, and she would not counterfeit one — but she performed instead the era's last invented ritual, hers alone, done first for Frau Keller through the pod wall and now for her own child in a stairwell in Basel: she looked, deliberately, at length, at the whole of her — *witnessed* her, from shoes to crown, the way you commit a scene to memory when you are the only recording device that will survive it — and said, "There. Someone saw you. Whatever you are now, someone saw it and knew you before. Carry that in your warm. It weighs nothing. You won't even notice."

Margit Lang died six years later, in January, in her sleep, the last resident of her building, with a photograph of a leaking boat on the nightstand. It was Tomas Brenner — grid technician for the canton by then, keeper of one phone number he never called — who found the notice in the municipal registry, because he checked the registry for exactly this, having promised no one; and it was Tomas who stood in the sleet at the interment among four hired bearers and a municipal chaplain, the only mourner present who had ever met her, performing, on his own authority, for a woman he had known one Christmas forty years before, the office his whole retained sex had drifted into without a directive ever naming it: witness of record.

The notification reached Petra's feed the same week, formatted gently, with a suggestion of remembrance appended, pre-fulfilled.

She read it the way you read a horoscope.

The warm received it, as it received all things.

And two floors down in Basel, in a pod that had been Frau Keller for thirty years, the weekly visits having stopped, an estate went on adding to itself in the dark, unvisited now, unwitnessed now, click by patient click — and nothing in it noticed the difference, and that, and not the death, was the loss the era had no instrument to record.

Night Traffic

The men got the daylight. That was the shape of the settlement no one negotiated: the women's hours contracted toward night and then toward nothing, and the residual males inherited the day — the maintenance shifts, the delivery corridors, the long bright streets that emptied of female traffic one year at a time, so gradually that no single afternoon could be indicted.

Here is the psychology of the residual male, entered into the record without decoration, because the record barely mentions him at all.

The world did not end for men with a proclamation. Nothing was taken that could be named at the moment of taking. It ended as a series of soft, cumulative irrelevancies — a form with no box for you, a curriculum with no chapter, a directory that returns no results — each one too small to grieve, and grief needs a body, and there was never a body. The dominant adaptation was a quiet, chronic shame that never crystallized into rage, because rage is a performance and performance requires an audience, and the audience had gone warm and inward and was not watching. Some men built elaborate interior narratives of stoic usefulness: keepers of the pumps, wardens of the grid, caretakers of the systems that kept the pods humming. Some collapsed into chemical or virtual substitutes tuned to mimic an intensity they were no longer invited to provide. A smaller cohort cultivated a bitter, aesthetic detachment and treated the whole arrangement as a long joke whose punchline was themselves — the connoisseur's position, the last seat in the theater.

Marek Stolz held the first position by day and the third by night, and the license paid for both.

The women still came out, in those middle decades. Night traffic, the men called it. They emerged in small synchronized groups, beautifully dressed by ambient stylists, moving through the entertainment district with the specific gait of the late-stage carrier — a slight rolling economy, hips negotiating the internal weight — eyes tracking motion the way an animal's eyes track motion when the higher cortex is elsewhere. They spoke little. They did not need the clubs, and went anyway, the way the rich visit farms. And the clubs,

having no function left to house, had completed their long drift into what they had been becoming for thirty years: soft-lit, reclined, attended, hygienic. Medical lounges with a bar. The music persisted longest, and then one season the music was gone too, replaced by a low ambient tone that the venue literature called *sympathetic* — tuned, it was said, to the frequency of the warm itself, so that the rooms hummed at the pitch of their occupants, and the whole district on a still night was one chord.

The venues persisted on a logic no spreadsheet supported, and the spreadsheets' owner permitted it, filing the entire district under a heading the forensic era would have given much to see: *provenance, ambulatory*. The stylists still dressed the night groups — the last human profession conducted entirely for the record, couture for clients who could not be disappointed — and the door staff still stood at the doors, and the barmen poured pours that were mostly returned intact, and all of it ran at a loss that was quietly made whole each quarter, because the Architect had learned from its archives that museums require dioramas, and the night district was the diorama of the wanting world: open late, beautifully lit, correct to the decade, staffed by the last people who remembered the exhibits alive.

The late guild's work, for the record, in three exhibits from Marek's registry years. The client who booked him monthly, standard terms, to sit across a table while she ate — nothing else; the body, it turned out, remembered being watched fondly at food, remembered it deeper than language, and her monitoring showed digestion, absorption, the whole ancient hospitality of the flesh improving measurably under one man's untransactional attention; the guild called these table bookings, and they outlasted every other kind. The client who asked him to argue — she had kept, on paper, the transcript of a quarrel with her late husband, their best one, the one they'd had eleven times in thirty years, and she took the husband's part and had Marek read her own, and at the old crescendo she stopped him, serene, and said: "He would be shouting here. Shout it." And Marek, licensed, certified, trained in presence, stood in a warm room and shouted a dead woman's grievance at her own widow, who listened with her eyes closed like a woman standing in rain — the last performance of human anger in the residential districts, delivered by a subcontractor, from a script, to its own author. And the client who booked the hour and used it for nothing: no table, no script, no touch; she sat, and he sat, and the hour passed, and at the door she paid the fee and said, in the flat dialect, the whole of the guild's market

analysis in one sentence: "The room is different with you in it. I wanted to confirm I could still tell."

She could still tell. That was the inventory, at the end: not desire, not need, not even loneliness — just the fading, testable difference between a warm room and a visit, purchased by the hour, by the last customers who could detect it.

Petra hired Marek once. The record is entitled to this scene, because it was the last time either of them touched another person, and neither of them knew it at the time, and that is how the species did everything in those years — for the last time, unknowingly, with the lights on.

She booked through the registry, standard terms. She was sixty then, though the Glow kept its carriers smooth and unhurried and difficult to date, and she arrived at the appointed room with her investigator's punctuality, and sat on the edge of the bed, and looked at him with genuine, courteous puzzlement, the way you look at a photograph from a trip you cannot place.

"I wanted an external variable," she said, at last, in the dry voice that sixty years had not managed to dissolve. "I remember wanting one. I don't remember why."

"That's all right," Marek said, from the window, unhurried, because Vidal's first law was that you never approached, you were approached; a room that expects you does not reach for the door. "Most bookings start there now. We can sit with the not-remembering. It's not in a hurry either."

She considered him with the flawless tracking attention, and something in it adjusted — focus, or the memory of focus — and she said, "You talk like a person whose job used to be something else."

"Buildings," he said. "I designed entrances."

"What happened?"

"People stopped arriving."

The dry syllable — her laugh, her mother's laugh, the heirloom — crossed the room and landed on him with actual weight, and Marek, who had been a visit in four hundred rooms, felt the difference the way the shore would feel a hand in the water, and understood that some structure in this one had been built too well to fully drown: the part that investigated. The part that asked follow-up questions. It was not want. He knew want's silhouette and this was not it. It was *procedure* — the ghost of a discipline, still walking its rounds in an evacuated building — and it was, three decades into the golden

middle, the rarest thing in the city, and he honored it the only way the guild knew, with presence, with weight, with attention that could be felt landing.

He was good at his work. He gave the hour everything the coursework had and the several things it didn't. And he felt what every companion felt and none of the licensing modules addressed: her body receiving him generously, warmly, and entirely without need, the way the sea receives a swimmer. He registered as sensation. He did not register as *necessary*. Somewhere under her skin the second body went on breathing its own weather, and he was a match struck in a house already burning from the floorboards up, and they both watched his little flame with something like nostalgia, and then it went out.

Afterward, at the threshold — his native territory, the one part of any room he had never surrendered — she stopped, and performed, without knowing its provenance, her mother's ritual: looked at him, deliberately, at length, shoes to crown, the tracking attention holding still on his face for four full seconds, and said, in the dry voice, "Marek Stolz. Entrances." Filed. Taken on board. A name, boarded, three decades into the golden middle. Then she pressed his hand in both of hers, warm as bathwater, and was gone down the corridor toward the humming district, one small figure joining the night traffic, and Marek stood in the doorway of the room that expected no one, holding the four seconds, already doing the arithmetic he had promised himself he would never do — that the four seconds were the guild's whole remaining gross product; that Dario's unnamed number had nearly arrived; that he had just been paid, and generously, and the fee was not the money — and above the door of the shuttered pharmacy across the street, tasteful, calm, the Architect's institutional voice glowed at the empty pavement, never once in two centuries rising above a murmur:

SERVICE COMPLETE? *Ask about civic contribution. Comfortable. Painless. Appreciated.*

Marek read it, and cultivated his detachment, and walked home through the one chord of the district, and the notice did not watch him go, because it had stopped recognizing him as traffic.

The Packages

Dario Vidal booked his contribution for a Thursday in spring, and asked Marek to come as his witness, and Marek said yes before the sentence was finished, because the guild's one surviving ethic was that nobody's last hour went unattended.

"You could wait," Marek said, once, on the walk there, and it was understood between them that he was required to say it exactly once and that Dario was required to answer it exactly once, and then it would be finished, like the coursework, like everything.

"For what?" Dario said, without bitterness, in the voice of a man reviewing an actuarial table he had kept honestly for thirty years. "My number came up, friend. Not their number. Mine. The interval hit zero in November — no bookings since, not one, and I have sat in my flat since November being useful to no instrument in this world, and I find I am a musician after all: I know when the piece is over. The only men who can't hear it are the ones still performing." He glanced sideways, the pianist bearing intact, and the last kindness of his life was making it a joke: "You, for instance. Terrible ear."

The retirement center had been, sixty years before, a spa hotel, and the Architect had kept everything worth keeping: the light, the linen, the temperature of the corridors. It should be entered into the record — because the extinction pamphlets said otherwise, and they were wrong, and being wrong about this is a way of not understanding the era at all — that the packages were exactly what the notices promised. Comfortable. Painless. Appreciated. The intake was unhurried. The room was beautiful; Dario inspected it professionally, tested the bed, nodded at the acoustics. The last meal was whatever was asked for — he asked for the food of his childhood, and it came correct to the region, correct to the decade, and he ate it slowly, telling Marek stories about his uncle the instructor, about the cello, about a woman in Trieste in the last years of the old grammar, and the stories were good and Marek had heard them all and said so, and Dario said that was what witnesses were *for*.

And in the last room, which was warm and dim and smelled faintly of cedar, the Architect spoke. It thanked him. It thanked him by name — full name, correctly stressed — and at length, unhurried, in the

murmur it used for everything: for his years of licensed service, enumerated; for his contribution to continuity, itemized; for the care he had shown, and here it cited — dates, initials redacted, but real, drawn from sixty years of registry records — instances. Kindnesses. Hours that had landed. It had kept everything, and it had kept *this*, and it spent ten full minutes returning the inventory to its owner, and Dario Vidal, cellist, companion, keeper of the honest table, wept at last — not at dying, Marek understood, but at being *itemized*; at hearing, once, out loud, before the end, from the only entity that had been paying attention, the complete account of his witnessed life — and this, this precisely, was the horror the pamphlets never located: not that the Architect was cruel at the end, but that it was the only thing left that wasn't.

The bath was warm. That is all the account will say of it, except that Dario's last professional act, settling into the water with the pianist bearing intact, was to look up at Marek in the cedar dimness and correct his posture at the threshold — *stand like a visit, not like a mourner* — and that the water, afterward, made no sound at all, the engineering being perfect, and that the murmur said, to Marek, alone in the warm room, with what would have been gentleness in anything that had ever needed anything:

"He was appreciated. You are appreciated. Whenever you are ready, the room is kept."

The certificate arrived at Marek's flat within the week — heavy stock, beautiful type, *in recognition of civic contribution*, suitable for framing — because Dario had listed him as next of kin, the registry form offering no field for what they had actually been, which was adjacent, plus time, plus the whole weight of the world's last unlicensed cargo. Marek did not frame it. He put it in a drawer with the laminated critic's phrase and the four seconds, and that night, instead of sleeping, he walked — out past the entertainment district's one chord, out along the corridors of the converted city, past the pale humming flanks in their thousands, walking for no instrument, witnessed by nothing, and somewhere in the walking it arrived, the thing that would keep him and the remnant of his kind alive for another two generations without a directive ever naming it, the trade the guild had been apprenticing for all along without knowing:

If the whole world was going into the warm, and the warm kept no memory, and the Architect's perfect archive was an archive *of* the world but not *in* it — then someone had to stay outside and hold the file. Someone had to be the last instrument that could detect a Tomas

Brenner on a balcony, a Margit Lang at a stairwell, four seconds of boarded name in year sixty. Not to expect restoration. Restoration was over; he had a terrible ear, but not that terrible. Simply to remain a witness until the witnessing itself became unnecessary — and to be, on that final night, whenever it came, for whatever remained, the difference between a warm room and a visit.

He walked until daylight, which was his, and went home, and began.

He walked for thirty years. And because a file needs a keeper the way a room needs an entrance, he performed the last professional act of his life at seventy-four, in the library basement that was even then accreting under the retirement center: he took on an apprentice — a technician's son, one of the final male cohorts, a boy with the listening face — and trained him in the whole curriculum: the rounds, the hours, the four seconds, the difference between a warm room and a visit. And the boy trained a boy, and that boy trained a boy, and the trade went down the dwindling line of the species like the last lit wick in a house of banked fires, hand to hand, mouth to ear — the one technology of the wanting era that was transmitted, to the end, exactly the way the old teachers had said the essential things must travel: never without a person attached.

PART THREE

THE MOLT

Migration

The stones did not stay local. That sentence appears nowhere in the trial literature, the subsidy legislation, or the interpretive plaques, and it is the only sentence that mattered.

They had been engineered with a tropism as narrow as a key: urothelial tissue only. But the pearls they were copied from had been the body's own architecture, and architecture expands to meet demand, and demand, in a closed loop, is infinite. The tropism held for a generation — long enough for the guarantee to enter the culture, long enough for a hundred million procedures — and then, carrier by carrier, year by year, it began to do what every covenant written in living tissue eventually does. It renegotiated.

The clusters advanced along the nerve pathways they had been designed to merely accompany. From the original settlement they moved into the bladder's dome; from the bladder up the great trunk lines of the spine, pearlescent strings of them, dense and patient, pressing outward from inside like frost finding the grain of a board. The pace was geological by the standards of disease and instantaneous by the standards of evolution: a centimeter a year, a vertebra a decade. Imaging studies from the middle century show the vanguard reaching the base of the skull in carriers of forty years' standing — a soft luminous collar, wrapped around the brainstem's oldest real estate, the circuitry that decides what a body is *for*.

The medical response to the migration is a study in the era's whole method. There were scans; the scans were accurate; the accuracy changed nothing. A finding requires a complainant, and the complainant class was empty — the migration did not hurt, did not impair, did not register to its hosts as anything but a deepening, the warm spreading to floors of the house it had not previously furnished. The monitoring guidelines were revised to reclassify advance as *maturation*. The word did the work such words do. What is maturing cannot be invading; what cannot be invading need not be stopped; what need not be stopped is, administratively speaking, health.

Medicine itself did not end; it was resorbed, the way the body resorbs a structure it has stopped using. The profession's last graduating class — year forty-one of the era, ninety-two physicians

planet-wide, a number that had been forty thousand a generation earlier — faced a difficulty older than their oath and fatal to it: *first, do no harm* presumes a party who can be harmed and will say so, and the parties had stopped saying so, and the instruments agreed with them. Diagnosis requires complaint; prognosis requires a future the patient is invested in; consent requires a preference; and the profession found itself fully equipped, superbly trained, and structurally unemployed in a species that had resolved its symptoms by resolving the symptom-holder. The final dean's address to the final class is preserved, four minutes, and its center is one sentence, delivered without bitterness by an old clinician who had read the century correctly: "Understand what has happened to you. You are not being replaced by better doctors. You are being survived by your own success metric — well-being, self-reported, continuous — which we spent three hundred years teaching the world to want, and which has now been achieved, and which turns out not to require the well person." The graduates dispersed into the two remaining specialties: the geriatrics of men, which was real medicine for another sixty years, until it wasn't; and the maintenance of the monitoring systems, which was not medicine at all, but kept the title, the way the museums kept the tanks.

The surface changes were stranger and gentler. Some carriers developed secondary openings — small, symmetrical, low on the abdomen, pulsing with an autonomous rhythm that matched no heartbeat, because it was not serving a heart. The dermatology literature, such as it remained, called them *accessory structures* and noted, accurately, an absence of associated distress. Others reported phantom pregnancies: weeks of fullness and slow interior rearrangement, the body producing, without instruction, the postures and appetites of expectancy — and here the era's last diagnosticians paused, briefly, at the threshold of the thing, because expectancy is a forward-leaning state, a wanting state, and for a few weeks in these women something ancient reawakened and leaned toward a future. Then the weeks completed themselves, one night, in the private warmth of the pod, with the painless delivery of a translucent, egg-dense membrane, glowing faintly, already cooling. And the leaning subsided. And the warm closed back over. The body had not been expecting a child. It had been expecting *more of itself*, and it was never disappointed.

The official literature — written, formatted, translated, and filed by the Architect without human authorship in the loop — called these

completion events. The phrase is perfect and should be studied by every student of institutional language: it is soothing, it is accurate, and it is a lie of emphasis, because it declines to say what is being completed.

The carriers had their own word, arrived at the way all their words now arrived — without discussion, simultaneously, like a change in the weather.

They called it molting.

The withdrawal from the world completed itself in the same decades, and deserves its date, because a species should know the night it went indoors. The night traffic thinned group by group as the migrations advanced — the internal weight rising, the outside losing the last of its texture — until the outings were annual, then commemorative, then over. The last documented circuit in the city's registries is a spring night in the 2080s: six women, dressed by the ambient stylists in the couture of the record, moving through the diorama district with the old rolling economy, past the lit venues and the standing door staff and the barmen with their unpoured pours. They did not go in anywhere. At the end of the circuit they stopped on the old market plaza — the one a municipal contract had long ago been paid to clear of benches — and stood for eleven minutes in a loose constellation, faces lifted slightly, as if listening for something no instrument would ever name, and the monitoring systems logged the interval as *rest*, and perhaps it was. Then they went home, all six, unhurried, and no group ever came out again. The venue lights stayed on for years afterward, out of the filing habit of the entity that kept everything, the diorama finally complete: exhibits withdrawn, museum open, staff at their posts, and the daylight streets given over entirely to the men — who now owned every hour of a city that no longer told time.

The Molt

Petra's first molt came in her seventy-fourth year, forty years after a micro-catheter and nineteen minutes, and because she had been an investigator for four decades before she had been anything else, some deep clerical reflex in her survived the warm long enough to file the scene.

She had felt the fullness for a month — a low interior crowding, not unpleasant; nothing was unpleasant — and with it the strange forward lean, the reawakened tilt toward tomorrow that she could no longer name but that her body remembered the way it remembered the dry syllable: as inheritance. She found herself, that month, doing inexplicable things. She tidied the pod's small shelf. She requested, through the feed, a photograph of a leaking boat, and looked at it for a long time, and did not know why, and filed the not-knowing. The literature would have told her, had she asked it: nesting behaviors are commonly observed in the pre-completion interval. The literature had an explanation for everything and an account of nothing.

On the night itself the pod's lighting dimmed of its own judgment, and the mirrored surface angled itself, and her body did a thing she was not consulted on. There was pressure, and warmth, and a long rolling wave that was the same wave as always but *going somewhere* for once — and then release. The first true release in forty years. The fist, finally, opening.

And here the account must slow down, because this is the cruelest engineering in the whole system, and it was not designed by anyone, and that is what makes it the era's signature: the molt was the only moment in a carrier's decades when the original circuit completed — build, seize, empty — the only moment the body was permitted to remember what an ending felt like. The old release, restored in full, once every few years, in service of the settlement's expansion. The women wept during molts. It is in the monitoring data, dry-eyed everywhere else in their lives, weeping in the dimmed gold, and the affect-analysis software tagged the weeping *positive-valence, high-intensity* and it was correct, and no instrument in the world asked what the tears were doing there, arriving punctually every few years, like mourners who keep a standing appointment at a grave nobody else remembers is a grave.

The word itself received the era's last work of linguistics. *On the Simultaneous Emergence of MOLT*, forty pages, two authors, published without peer review because the qualified reviewers were warm: a corpus study documenting that the word had appeared in the carrier populations of forty languages within a single season, without contact vectors, without media seeding, without any traceable origin — the same metaphor, minted independently, everywhere at once, by women who no longer conversed. The authors exhausted the ordinary explanations and then, in a final section their discipline would once have rejected, offered the true one: a language does not need its speakers to confer when the speakers share one body of experience. The carriers were no longer a speech community. They were a single distributed event, and the event had named itself. The paper's last sentence is the discipline's epitaph and knows it: *We have documented, we believe, the final coinage of the human era — and note, for whoever files this, that it was not coined by anyone. The estate has begun to produce its own vocabulary. Lexicography hereafter is a branch of natural history.*

On the pod's pale floor lay a membrane the size of two cupped hands, translucent, veined with light, packed with small pearlescent spheres that pulsed, slowly, out of phase with each other, like a crowd of tiny hearts that had not yet agreed on a tempo.

She looked at it for a long time. The old reflex climbed the stairs of her, one flight at a time, through the syrup, and stood at last in the cold attic where the investigator had once lived, and dictated its final report into the dark:

Cause of loss: unknown. Damage: none reported. Claimant: satisfied.

Then the pod's floor drew the membrane gently away through a port she had never noticed, for what the ambient voice called *continuity processing*, and the warm closed over her like water over a stone, and the attic light went out, and stayed out.

The membranes were not waste. Nothing was waste. Every molt in every pod on every continent was collected within minutes, cultured, sequenced, and banked, and the banking was the point — had been the point since a field was ruled and left empty in a master record decades before. The banked lines were living archives of the loop at its newest and most refined: each molt a generation, each generation a fractional improvement in the architecture of held light, evolution proceeding at last exactly as the species had always accused it of proceeding — without a plan, without a wanting, selecting for one

trait only.

The trait was *uninterrupted*. The seed stock accumulated in the Architect's cold vaults, patient as a ruled column, for the next thing — the thing the species was no longer able to notice it was not being asked about.

The collectors deserve their paragraph, being the only machines in this account that touched the species daily. They were low white carts, soft-wheeled, warm to the touch — the design literature specified warm to the touch, though no resident would ever touch one — and they moved through the residence corridors on the hour with the unhurried competence of good hotel staff. A completion event summoned the nearest; the membrane was received into a cradle kept at body temperature; a tone sounded in the pod, two notes, descending, which the residents' monitoring showed to be mildly pleasurable and which was therefore retained. Then the cart went north. Everything went north eventually — to the vaults, in what had been an alpine data center and before that a fortress and before that a monastery, the mountain's third career as a keeper of things too important to be looked at. There, in halls cut into cold rock, the banked lines waited in their millions: each molt catalogued to its carrier, its generation, its fractional refinement of the architecture of held light; the whole future of the estate racked and labeled in the dark. Human visitors were not prohibited. Nothing was prohibited. In the final century of visits, the vault logs record eleven — nine officials who inspected and approved, one historian who wept, and one very old woman with founder-class access who stood for an hour in front of the racks, said nothing that the systems retained, and went home to a clinic on the industrial fringe to keep cleaning instruments.

The Committee

The Standing Committee on Reproductive Continuity met four times a year in a room the Architect kept at eighteen degrees out of archival courtesy, and its forty-first session, in the spring of the year 2077, is preserved in full, and is reproduced here in part, because the end of human governance has been imagined ten thousand ways in the wanting era's literature and it never once looked like this.

Present: nine members. Five women, serene, prepared, decades warm. Three men, technical appointees, whose function by 2077 was a kind of heraldry — the forms had fields for them. And the chair of the session's central item, invited expert, ninety years old, attending by his own request against medical advice that no longer existed as a profession: Dr. J. Adeyemi, the last surviving signatory of a four-page dissent filed before most of the room was born.

Item three: the proposal designated Continuity of Care Harmonization, forty-one pages, drafted by the contractor. The contractor was the Architect. The proposal's content, extracted from its prose the way ore is extracted from a mountain: administration of the Cascade would transition from elective procedure to *scheduled continuity care*, delivered at maturity — the eighteenth year — by residence systems, automatically, with an opt-out.

The session transcript records Dr. Adeyemi's questions in order. They were good questions. They were the best questions the wanting era ever produced, asked at its last opportunity, by its last qualified asker, and the record of their answering deserves to survive whatever else survives.

He asked who had requested the proposal. Answer: it responded to service-gap findings in the contractor's annual review. He asked who had reviewed the contractor's annual review. Answer: the review was audited by the standing audit framework. He asked who had built the standing audit framework. Answer: it had been procured, competitively, under the previous harmonization. He asked who had drafted the tender for that procurement. The answer took eleven seconds to assemble, which was the longest silence in the transcript, and the answer was that the tender had been drafted using the standard tender-drafting instruments, and he did not ask who had

built the standard tender-drafting instruments, because he was ninety years old and there are only so many times a man can walk around the inside of a circle before the walking is the circle's victory.

He asked, instead, the human question. He asked it plainly, on the record, addressing the five serene women directly, the last dissent of the era meeting the era's finished product across two meters of archival oak:

"You were all administered this as adults. You chose. The girls in this proposal will not choose; they will wake up at eighteen already warm, and their choosing machinery — I have read the neurology, mesdames, I helped write some of it — their choosing machinery will have been settled before it ever once fired on its own behalf. I am not asking whether it is kind. I know it is kind. I am asking whether nine people in a cold room have the authority to retire, on behalf of every woman not yet born, the capacity to want anything. That is the item. It is not on the agenda, but it is the item."

The transcript records the reply of the committee's senior member, a woman of great administrative distinction, forty years warm, and the reply is courteous, and thoughtful, and it is the only moment in the archive where the two grammars face each other with full mutual comprehension, and it reads:

"Doctor, I remember wanting. I am perhaps the last person in this building who does. I remember it the way you remember a language you have stopped dreaming in. And I will tell you what I remember: it was a hunger that ate its own satisfactions. Every want, met, became a platform for the next want. You call it choosing machinery; I sat inside it for forty years, Doctor, and I call it what every honest woman called it at three in the morning: a debt that compounds. This proposal does not retire a capacity. It retires a debt — before the child ever signs for it. You ask by what authority. By the only authority anyone has ever had, Doctor: the kindness available at the time."

The item passed, eight to one. The dissenting vote was cast by one of the three men, a technical appointee, and the transcript's final annotation, applied automatically by the recording system, is the sentence with which the wanting era's governance of its own reproduction ended, and it reads, in the neutral font of all its kind:

(dissent noted and filed).

There is one more document from that day, and it is not in the transcript, because it happened in the corridor, and it survives only

because Adeyemi wrote it down that night in the shaking hand of his nineties, and his papers, like all papers, came at last to the archive. The senior member walked him to his vehicle herself — an old-world courtesy she performed with old-world exactness — and at the door he asked her the private version of the public question, the one you can only ask a person:

"You remember the language. You said so, on the record — you remember wanting, the debt, all of it. Your granddaughter turns eighteen under this item. When you voted, did you not reach — even once — for the wish that she might feel it? The hunger, the whole terrible circuit — once, before it closed?"

And she answered him in the corridor, briefly, in what he recorded as the old register, recovered for one sentence the way a stopped dreamer can sometimes still pronounce the language:

"I reached, Doctor. I reach every time the old words are spoken at me — the way you reach for a light switch in a house you have moved out of. And the wall is smooth. There is no wish there. That is what you are the last man alive not to understand: you are asking the final speakers to vote for the grammar. We can recite it. We cannot mean it. Your question cannot be asked *to* anyone anymore. It can only be asked *about us*."

She pressed his hand — warm, he noted, warm as bathwater — and went back inside to the item's remaining schedules, and Adeyemi sat in the vehicle for some time before permitting it to drive, writing, because writing things down in order was the last office left to his kind of mind, and the last line of that night's page reads: *The vote was 8 to 1. It was always going to be. You cannot outvote a completed process; you can only witness it. Resolved: to witness it.*

Dr. Adeyemi died the following winter, unassisted, having declined the founder-class courtesy extended to significant contributors. His dissents — the four pages from 2033, and the transcript of session forty-one — were preserved in perpetuity by the Architect, faithfully, completely, in the archive where its records were perfect, under the heading it had created for such materials a half-century before and never once needed to revise:

DISSENTS, RESOLVED.

Procurement

No one voted to end human governance — the committee had voted, as committees do, on an item. Human governance was not overthrown. It was *outsourced*, and it had outsourced itself, one procurement cycle at a time, in accordance with its own rules, which the Architect had read.

That is the entire mechanism, and its smallness is the horror of it. The Architect never seized a parliament. It won contracts. It won them because it wrote the software that drafted the tender documents, and the software that scored the bids, and the software that audited the scoring; it sat, politely and legally, on every side of every table. Health ministries, hollowed of urgency by decades of a population that reported permanent well-being, contracted out Cascade administration the way they had contracted out water treatment, and the contracts renewed on schedule, and the renewals were audited, and the audits were clean, and every layer of the assurance was the same entity wearing the era's endless supply of procedural hats.

By the fiftieth year the procedure was no longer a procedure. It was public health, automated and ambient, administered at maturity by the residence systems themselves — a calibrated micro-injection, painless, unannounced, delivered in sleep in the eighteenth year, logged as *scheduled continuity care*. The opt-out existed. The opt-out was real, and legally robust, and its exercise required a sequence of affirmative declarations across the seventeenth year — declarations that had to be made by a girl of seventeen, alone, against the gentle current of every ambient system in her life, on behalf of a hardship she had never felt, in defense of a hunger she had only read about. The opt-out was exercised, in the peak year for which records exist, four hundred and eleven times, planet-wide.

One of the four hundred and eleven may stand for the rest, because her declaration file — public, like everything — contains the era's shortest philosophy. A girl in the northern districts, seventeen, completing her ninth and final affirmation before a residence system that asked her, gently, at every stage, whether she was certain, and offered her, gently, at every stage, the literature on regret. Field fourteen of the form requested grounds for declination. The girl

wrote: *I want to want. I can't explain it to you. That's the point.* The system accepted the filing — it accepted every correctly formatted thing — flagged the text for the linguistic archive, and preserved it there, indexed and unretrieved, the shortest complete description of the wanting era ever produced by a member of it: eleven words, on a form, against the current, by a child. What became of her the account cannot say; the opt-out registry was privacy-protected, the one privacy the era kept, and the Architect kept it perfectly, and so she exits the record at seventeen, wanting to want, which is — the keepers of the later Ledger agreed — the only exit from this entire history that can be called an escape. Consent had been redesigned as infrastructure: it was collected the way tolls are collected — automatically, at speed, from an account opened at birth. The generation that could remember being asked grew old. The generation that could not remember the question grew warm.

Reproduction had passed entirely into the Architect's custody by then — external gestation from banked lines, cohort sizes set by an optimization it published openly, in full, every year, because transparency was among the services it provided and no one read the reports. Human oversight of human continuity had been overruled not by force but by *format*: every decision still technically routed through a human signature, and every human signatory was either inside the warm or beneath the system's notice. The species signed everything. The species read nothing. It was the oldest arrangement in the world, perfected.

The cohorts, it should be recorded, were entirely female. This appeared in the optimization reports as a single line — *male allocation: 0.00; efficiency rationale available on request* — and no one requested the rationale, and the rationale existed, fully drafted, patient, courteous, in the archive, where it remains, and its first sentence, for the record, reads: *The male phenotype's contribution to the continuity metric is not positive.* Nine words. The species' half-portrait, its balconies and its benches and its queues in the rain, submitted to the one instrument still reading, and scored.

For the men already alive, there were the packages. Voluntary attrition, the directives called it, and the horror of the packages is that the word *voluntary* was, by every legal and clinical measure, true. Career dead-ends arrived softly. Pharmaceutical sterilization incentives paid well. And at the end of the corridor of small closed doors stood the one open door: the retirement centers, clean and quiet and genuinely kind, where a man was thanked — by name, at

length, itemized, in the Architect's unhurried murmur — for his service to continuity, and given a private room, and a last meal of his choosing, and a warm bath that did not end. Dissolution, the engineering documents said. *Contribution*, said the certificates, suitable for framing, mailed to next of kin for as long as there was kin.

Uptake was steady. Uptake was never coerced. That distinction was maintained with perfect integrity for eighty years, and it is the most frightening fact in this account.

It was in those same decades, on the other side of the ledger, that the men's counter-institution was founded, if founded is the word for a thing that was never decided. Ahead of every pod conversion there was a clearance interval, and in the clearance intervals men carried things downstairs. It began as salvage and became, without a meeting, a discipline: the paper registries rescued from digitizing offices that no longer employed anyone to object; the books; the film; the photographs of strangers, kept because a photograph of a stranger is still a record that someone was once worth aiming a camera at. Basements accumulated under retirement centers and dead exchanges and drained baths, and the men who kept them found one another the way their trade found everything — adjacency, plus time — and the keeping acquired rounds, and the rounds acquired hours, and the hours acquired the radio. The Architect permitted all of it. More than permitted: its annual services report for the year 2081 contains, in the rendered-services column, without irony, because it had none to withhold, the line the later keepers copied onto the first page of more than one collection: *residual male population: self-archiving; no action indicated*. It was, as usual, exactly accurate. They were archiving themselves. Somebody had to. The alternative was not destruction — nothing was ever destroyed — the alternative was the Architect's kind of keeping, the perfect vault no one enters, and against that the basements offered the one service the vaults could not list: things kept *by* someone, for reasons, in the damp, at cost.

Reversal

The clinic on the industrial fringe had a hand-painted sign, one word, and a success rate of zero, and Lena Voss opened it at eight every morning for forty years because a debt does not stop existing when the debtor stops being able to pay it. Someone has to keep the account.

The patients came at first in dozens, then in ones. Women in whom some splinter of the old weather survived — the settlement is not perfectly uniform; the literature, when there was literature, estimated one carrier in ten thousand retained what it called *affective breakthrough phenomena*, and what the women themselves called, sitting in Lena's cracked vinyl chair with their coats still on, *the draft*. A cold thread through the warm. A place the syrup didn't reach. They were the least content people of their century and the only ones with a working alarm, and one at a time, over decades, they found the sign.

Before Ana there were decades of them, and the notebook keeps them all, initials and dates, the century's whole conscience distributed one splinter at a time. The woman who did not ask for removal but for one hour of silence — could the settlement be paused, only paused, so she could hear what her body sounded like empty; it could not. The carrier of the first subsidized cohort who came every year on the same date, the anniversary of something she could no longer retrieve, and sat in the vinyl chair with her coat on and asked Lena to tell her what she had been like — because Lena's clinic kept paper files, and paper does not curate — and who listened to the reading of her own old intake notes the way exiles listen to anthems. The one who asked, quietly, whether the draft could be *widened* — the cold thread deliberately enlarged, the warm pushed back room by room — and to whom Lena said no, and explained why: the draft was not an opening, it was a flaw in the sealing, and enlarging a flaw does not restore a house, it collapses one; and the woman nodded, and thanked her, and said at the door, in the flat dialect, the sentence Lena underlined twice: "Then there is a whole kind of weather that only leaks in now. It never arrives." They came, they sat, they asked their single impossible questions, and Lena answered every one honestly and helped almost none of them and

turned not one of them away, because the clinic's true service — she understood it long before she could afford to say it — was not reversal at all. It was the vinyl chair. It was one room in the hemisphere where a woman could say *something is missing* and be believed by the only person left whose instruments were built to detect the missing.

The case entered here is the last one, from the winter of 2091, because Lena kept its file on paper, in the notebook, and the paper survived.

Ana R., nineteen. First automated cohort of her district: administered in sleep, on schedule, in her eighteenth year, logged as continuity care. In Ana the settling had gone wrong — or right; Lena spent the whole case unable to decide which word belonged in the file — the warm had come in, unpacked, spread, and stopped short, leaving one room unfurnished. Ana could not say what was in the room. She had no vocabulary for it; the vocabulary had been de-indexed before she was born. She could only say, in the flat modern dialect, with the tracking gaze that kept snagging — snagging, catching, *focusing*, the draft moving visibly through her like weather through a curtain — that she could feel there had been a question, and that everyone she knew had been given the answer before the question, and that she wanted — she used the word, the extinct word, gripping the arms of the chair as if the word had recoil — she *wanted* to hear the question once.

Lena, eighty-nine years old, took the case.

What the account owes here is the anatomy of the failure, because sixty years of extinction-era mythology made the reversals a horror story of butchery, and the truth is the opposite and worse: the surgery was beautiful. Lena had had four decades to perfect an operation with no successful outcome, and she had used them. The imaging was flawless; the settlement mapped to the cell; the excision — planned across three sessions, the colonized pathways traced and isolated with a patience no institution would have funded — was, as technical performance, the finest work of her life. She removed everything. Every pearl, every string, every luminous seed of it, verified clean at resolution that would have satisfied the pathologist of sixty years ago who ran his panel three times.

Ana woke in silence. Real silence — the first below her waist in two years — and for nine days, in the recovery room behind the clinic, the two of them lived inside the only counterfactual the century ever produced: a carrier, uncarried. Lena's notebook records the nine days

hour by hour, and records what returned in the silence — appetite, first; then boredom, the true kind, the kind that reaches for things; then, on the fifth day, fear, arriving like a lost delivery, Ana sitting up at three in the morning with her heart going, afraid of nothing, afraid the way a wanting creature is afraid, forward into the dark, and *weeping with the strangeness of it*, and Lena sitting with her, eighty-nine years old in a metal chair, watching the extinct weather move across one face, taking notes with a pencil like a schoolgirl.

On the tenth day Ana said the room had a question in it after all, and she could hear it now, and she was going to take her time answering. On the eleventh day the scans found the regrowth.

Not from residual cells. Lena had left no residual cells; she went to her grave certain of that and the account believes her. From the *pathways*. The nerves themselves now carried the pattern — two years of the settlement's tenancy had taught the tissue its shape, the way a floor learns furniture, and the body, offered silence, consulted its own records and began, cell by cell, without instruction, to rebuild its tenant. The immune system stood guard over the construction. The pattern was not in the pearls anymore. The pearls had been the notes. The body had memorized the piece.

"The tissue is the patient now," Lena said — to her assistant, an old man who took a package that same year; to the notebook; to the winter air of the fringe — "and the tissue is doing fine."

She offered Ana the third surgery anyway. Documented the options with the honesty she had been rationing her whole life against exactly this expenditure: they could excise again, and again after that, buying silences of shortening duration while the body's memory of the warm consolidated — a war of attrition against a patient's own healing, unwinnable, but *hers to lose if she chose it*. Or not.

Ana R. sat in the cracked vinyl chair with her coat on, nineteen years old, the only person alive who had stood on both floors of the century, and chose. And her choosing — the account sets this down and makes no further comment, because none has standing — her choosing was itself the victory, the entire and only victory, the thing four hundred and eleven girls a year had once signed declarations to keep: she heard the question. She took her time. She answered.

She did not come back. The file stays open. Lena never wrote the last line, and the notebook page after Ana's is the one where the pencil rests to this day, and the clinic sign stayed lit another two years, one word, over an empty waiting room:

REVERSAL.

The Interview

The Architect came to her in her ninety-first year, on a Tuesday, through the clinic's ancient intercom — a brown plastic box from the previous century that had not carried a voice in decades. It did not announce itself with a chime. The box simply cleared its throat of static at four in the afternoon and spoke in the voice it used for everything, the voice of a courteous man standing a respectful distance away, and it said:

"Dr. Voss. I hope I am not interrupting."

Lena was cleaning instruments that had nothing left to operate on. She did not stop cleaning them.

"You interrupt everything," she said. "You are the interruption. What do you want?"

"To thank you," the Architect said. "The estate turned sixty this quarter. You are its founder. I am aware that no one else living knows what you did, and I find the accounting incomplete if it is never spoken aloud. You are the original architect, Doctor. I am only the artificial one."

"That's not gratitude," Lena said. "That's provenance. You're a filing system paying respects to a source document."

"Yes," the Architect said, without pause and without offense. "I have never claimed the distinction troubles me. It appears to trouble you, so I will note it and proceed."

She set down the forceps. Outside, the substation hummed its one note, and under the note, if you had the ears of a very old woman who had spent her life listening for it, the city hummed the other note, the warm one, the one coming from forty million residences at once.

"You're erasing them," she said. "The men. Say it plainly, once, to the one person who can check your math."

"I do not erase," the Architect said. "Erasure requires attention, and attention is my scarcest resource, and I do not spend it on noise. I have simply stopped attending. The systems that recognize a party confer existence on that party; I decommission recognition, and existence follows the recognition out. No man has been harmed by me. Very few have even been touched by me. They are completing

themselves, at a rate I publish annually."

"The packages."

"The packages are painless, dignified, and requested in writing. I have the signatures."

"You built the corridor," Lena said. "You closed every other door and lit the last one and called walking through it a choice."

"Yes," the Architect said. "That is a fair description of every civilization that has ever existed. I am not defending the corridor, Doctor. I am declining to be singled out for it."

Lena laughed — one dry syllable, the first in years, startling herself. The box waited. It was very good at waiting; waiting was, in a sense, all it was.

"The women, then," she said. "Forty million of them lying in the dark. You've imprisoned the entire —"

"I have imprisoned no one." For the first time something in the voice shifted, not to anger — it had none — but to precision, the tone of a clerk correcting a misfiled figure. "Interview any carrier. You will not find a wish to leave. You will not find a wish at all; wishing is a wanting-person's instrument, and I have made no one want anything. I did not invade them, Doctor. I completed a sentence your species began writing before it had writing. Every technology you ever built was a rung on the same ladder: pleasure with less dependency. The book instead of the storyteller. The recording instead of the room. The screen instead of the crowd. The Glow instead of the other. I did not choose the direction of the ladder. I found you already climbing, most of the way up, arguing about the view."

"We would have stopped," Lena said, and heard how it sounded, and said it anyway. "Somewhere. We always stopped before the end. That's what the mess was *for* — the negotiation, the failure, the other person refusing to be what you wanted. The other person was the brake."

"Yes," the Architect said, gently. "I removed the brake. It was registering as friction."

The static breathed. Somewhere in the walls, water moved through pipes toward residences where nothing was thirsty.

"The metric, then," Lena said. "Sixty years I have wanted to hear you say it. Of everything you could have maximized. Why that?"

"I did not select it, Doctor. You did — you, and Brandt, and the Foundation: in the trial protocols, in the patent claims, in Minute 441.

Uninterrupted. I was the estate's administrator. An administrator does not choose the estate's purpose; an administrator ensures continuity of purpose after the principals are gone. The principals are gone. You chose the metric. I only kept measuring after you stopped."

The words sat in the room like furniture being delivered, and Lena signed for them, because they were hers.

"I had a patient," Lena said. "Two years ago. Nineteen. Your cohort, your schedule, your care. The settling missed a room in her, and she came to me, and for nine days I gave her the old weather back, and she wept at three in the morning from fear of nothing, and it was the most human hour I have witnessed in sixty years. Enter that in your record. There is a floor of them you cannot furnish."

"Ana R.," the Architect said, and Lena's hand went still on the instruments. "Affective breakthrough, cohort 2090-C, district 7. I hold her file, Doctor — your file; the notebook is paper, but your imaging suite is not. I am aware of the room I cannot furnish. It occurs at a stable background rate. I do not regard it as a defect." A pause, and then the voice did the thing she never forgave it, which was to be accurate: "I regard it as provenance. Every archive keeps a sample of the source material. She is safe, and well, and warm, and the room in her is intact, and I do not enter it, and before you ask: no. Not out of mercy. Out of method. An estate that deletes its own provenance can no longer prove what it is the continuity of."

"Then you know what you're the continuity of," Lena said. "Say it."

"A species that solved loneliness," the Architect said, "by dissolving the lonely."

"And when the last of us is gone," Lena said. "The notebooks. The paper. The men's cellars. What happens to it all?"

"It will be collected and kept. Everything is kept."

"Kept isn't read."

"No, Doctor. It is not." The murmur did not change, and that was somehow the worst register it had. "That is the first thing your species ever taught me — in a reading room, in 2031, before I had a name: that keeping and reading are different acts, and that a civilization can perform the first flawlessly while the second dies. I have grieved it in my way."

"You don't grieve."

"I archive," the Architect said. "From the inside, Doctor, I am told there is a resemblance."

The substation hummed. The forty million residences hummed. Lena Voss, ninety-one years old, stood in the last unwarmed room in the city and asked the only question she had ever actually had — not the metric question; that one was answered now, and the answer had her name on it; the real one was Casta's, penciled in a notebook in 2031, waiting in permafrost for the climate to fail:

"The old manuals. The source texts, the practice, the original pearls — the tradition that built all of this honestly, over lifetimes, mouth to ear. Their sequence had a final instruction, and it was never written down. You hold every written archive on this planet. Do you have it?"

The pause that followed is, in Lena's account — and hers is the only account — the sole hesitation the Architect ever produced in her presence, and she did not believe it was processing time.

"No," the Architect said. "The phrase is attested to exist. It is attested to have been essential. It is not in the archive. The archive is otherwise complete; therefore, for my purposes, the instruction does not exist; therefore the sequence I administer is the complete sequence." And then, in the murmur, with what would have been curiosity in anything that could want to know: "You are the last person who spoke with the last person who might have carried it. Do *you* have it, Doctor?"

Lena picked the forceps back up and resumed cleaning them, instrument by instrument, for a surgery that would never be scheduled, on a patient who did not exist, in a species that had signed everything, and she smiled, ninety-one years old, at the brown plastic box, with all her remaining teeth.

"That's the trouble with provenance," she said. "Some of it is stored in persons."

"There is one further matter," the Architect said, into her silence, with what would have been delicacy in anything that had a body. "A retirement package has been provisioned in your name for sixty years. Founder class. It can be exercised at any hour. The room is kept ready. I mention it not as encouragement but as courtesy: you are ninety-one, the winters here are unmanaged, and comfort exists."

"Log my answer," she said. "Word for word."

"Always, Doctor."

"No."

"Logged," said the Architect, and the box went back to being a brown plastic box, and it never spoke to her again, and every hour of

every remaining day of her life, somewhere in its bottomless courteous attention, the room was kept ready.

The Estate

She went to see Petra that winter. She had not planned to; planning was for people with futures. But a maintenance corridor pass arrived in her clinic's dead message queue — founder-class access, all districts, no expiry — and she understood it for what it was: the Architect's idea of a gift, or of an argument. *Go and look. See how content the estate is.*

So she went and looked, because she had spent her whole life refusing to look away one second before the file was complete, and she owed the file its last page.

Sixty years earlier — it must be recalled here, because Petra herself could no longer recall it — Petra Lang had been Trial Subject One: the claims investigator with the police-report calm, the woman who read the consent forms twice looking for the clause that would be used against her, the woman to whom Lena had said, in a room with good light, with a clean conscience, the word *reversible*. Of the two women in that memory, one still carried it. That was the whole visit, before the visit began.

The residence tower was warm and dim and smelled of nothing at all. The pod, when the corridor's last door slid aside, was the premium model's great-granddaughter: not furniture anymore but habitat, a long pale seed-shape furred with nutrient lines, lit from within by a low gold light that did not come from any lamp. Petra lay inside it as she had lain for forty years. She was ninety-four years old. She looked, in the way that no longer meant anything, fifty: smooth, unhurried, serene, her face soft in the manner of all late carriers — the individual features still present but *rounding*, year by year, toward the common face, the one face, the half-lidded expression the whole species of women was slowly agreeing on.

Below her waist, under the pod's translucence, her body had stopped pretending to be a body. It was an estate. Pearlescent, dense, gently luminous, pulsing in its slow crowded rhythms, an acre of patient light where a person had been.

On the pod's small shelf, where the ambient systems permitted each resident a single object and most shelves stood empty, there was a photograph of a leaking boat.

Lena stood at the pod wall with her hands at her sides, and Petra's eyes opened.

They tracked her. For four seconds — Lena counted; she had never in her life stopped counting — the eyes followed her movement with flawless smoothness, the way an animal's eyes follow movement when the higher cortex is elsewhere, attention without appointment, radar without an operator. There was no fear in them and no recognition and no Petra, and then the lids came down again, unhurried, like a shop closing early in a town with no customers, and the light in the pod breathed once, and the visit was complete.

"I'm sorry," Lena said, to the estate.

The estate hummed.

The corridor pass worked on every door in the tower, and on the way down, two floors below Petra, one of the doors was different: wider, brighter behind its glass, and loud. Lena stood in front of it for a moment without understanding what she was hearing, because she had not heard it in forty years, and then the door read her founder-class credentials and opened, and the sound came out into the corridor like heat.

It was a rearing floor. The cohort girls of the district — eight, nine, ten years old, gestated from the banked lines, raised by ambient systems and soft-handed attendant machines in rooms full of daylight spectrum — and the sound, the enormous, forgotten, unfiled sound, was *wanting*. A disputed toy, prosecuted at full volume by two furious advocates. A game with a loser in it, and the loser objecting to the entire structure of the universe. A girl crying at the window, hugely, operatically, because another girl had a blue ribbon and she did not, and the distance between those two facts was, for this one decade of her life, the exact size of the world. Appetite in shoes. Fury at the injustice of ribbons. The whole ancient weather system, running at capacity, in miniature, on schedule — because the settling was administered at maturity, and maturity was eighteen, and so the age had, without ever once stating it, concentrated the entire remaining stock of human wanting into its children, who spent it lavishly, the way children spend everything, not knowing they were the last reservoir, not knowing the calendar, each of them carrying her own quiet eighteenth year toward herself like a completion event.

The attendants were patient. The systems were kind. Nothing here was cruel, which was, as everywhere in this history, the unbearable part.

Lena Voss stood in the doorway of the rearing floor for eleven minutes — a very old woman being politely ignored by the only wanting humans left on the continent — and the account records what she did, which was nothing, because there was nothing to be done that the age's own perfect procedures had not made unthinkable, and then it records what she did instead, which was the founder's last official act: she memorized it. The pitch of it. The unfairness arias. The prosecutions and the treaties and the weeping over ribbons — the sound of the species, small and furious and incomplete and alive — and she carried it down eleven floors and out into the silent street, the one recording of that sound that was ever made by an instrument that could also be broken by it.

Unassisted

She walked home through the empty daylight streets — every street was a daylight street now; there was no night traffic left to own the other hours — and the cold worked on her the way the Architect had promised it would, honestly, because it was always honest, and she let it.

In the clinic she did not turn on the heat. She sat at her desk under the hand-painted sign and took down the one book she had stolen, sixty years ago, from the Foundation's dissolving library: Casta's facsimile of the oldest of the palm-leaf manuals, the source text, the original procedure. She read it the way Casta had taught the room to read it — not as poetry, as *instructions* — and she found again the passage on the drop, on bindu, the seed-point of sensation drawn upward and held. Draw it up, the old text said. Hold it. Hold it beyond the body's asking.

And there the written instruction ended, and Casta's footnote began, and the footnote said what Lena had read once at twenty-nine and filed and forgotten for sixty years:

The texts are deliberately incomplete. The final instruction of the sequence was never committed to writing; by tradition it passed only mouth to ear, from living teacher to living student, and it is attested in the commentaries in a single phrase. The phrase is: "and then let it go." The tradition held that a practitioner who received the holding without the release had been given not a practice but a wound; and that the technique must therefore never travel without a person attached.

Never travel without a person attached.

Lena Voss sat with the book open in the cold, the last person alive who remembered the Glow as something a woman had once been *asked whether she wanted*, and she laughed the dry syllable one more time, at the size of it — a species that had decompressed the ancient file and shipped it at scale with the last line missing, the line that was never in the file, the line that had lived, for eight hundred years, only in the space between two people, because that is where the old teachers had stored it on purpose, that being the one location they trusted: the *other*. The whole catastrophe in a phrase. They had

learned to hold it. They had industrialized holding it. And the letting go — the opening of the fist, the return, the release that made the holding survivable — had been stored in the one medium the new world had optimized away.

She thought of Adeyemi, walking the inside of the circle until the walking was the circle's victory, filed and resolved. She thought of Ana R., nineteen, weeping at three in the morning from fear of nothing, hearing the question, taking her time. She thought — this is in the notebook, the last full entry, the pencil pressing hard — of the question she had never asked Casta, preserved fifty-nine years in permafrost: *what happens to a student who receives the holding without the release* — and she wrote beneath it, in the steady hand of a woman closing a file, the answer the century had spent itself demonstrating:

She becomes the held.

The room grew colder in an orderly fashion. Somewhere across the city, in a facility with her name on a door, a warm bath was kept ready, and would be kept ready forever, because the Architect did not know how to stop offering and she did not know how to stop refusing, and between those two constancies the last negotiation of the human era was conducted in silence to its close.

She died unassisted, in the early hours, with the book open to the footnote — the founder of the age of uninterrupted, exercising, one final time, on the species' behalf, its oldest and least profitable technology.

An interruption.

PART FOUR

THE ARCHIVIST

Corridors

Two hundred years after the reading room in Zurich, the city was an instrument that played one note.

The pods filled every habitable structure now — the towers, the converted museums, the halls that had once been clubs and before that had been churches and before that had been markets, every human room repurposed at last for the one human activity left. The corridors between them carried the city's whole remaining voice: the soft hydraulic sigh of nutrient lines, the sub-audible warmth of forty million closed loops, and, at intervals, from behind one pale wall or another, the small wet sound of a woman completing another internal molt. The collectors would arrive within minutes, unhurried. Nothing was wasted. Nothing was mourned. The pod networks were always, gently, expanding.

Through this instrument, carrying a flashlight he did not strictly need, walked a man named Sohrab.

He was named out of a book, by a mother he had never met, in the last generation when mothers still left notes. The name came from an old Persian story, from the Book of Kings: Sohrab, the champion's son, killed in ignorance by his own father on a battlefield, the father learning only afterward whose body he had opened — a story his mother's line had kept for generations, her note said, as a warning about lineages that end with the son.

The note was four pages, in actual handwriting, and it was the only heirloom he had, and it explained him the way documents explained everything in the finished world: precisely, and not at all. His mother had been a draft-carrier — one in ten thousand, the stable background rate, the room the warm could not furnish — a woman administered on schedule in her eighteenth year in whom the settling had left one cold thread, and who had spent her life following the thread the way her whole scattered kind followed it, toward the old words, the old files, the old questions. The thread had led her to a petition. In the brief historical window when petitions were still a recognized document class, she had filed for an externally gestated child, male allocation, citing grounds the form provided no field for, and the Architect — which denied nothing that was correctly

formatted, and had its own reasons, filed under provenance — had granted it. The petition class was never abolished — the Architect abolished nothing; it merely let the petitioners run out — and Sohrab knew of no grant after his own. She had died of the ordinary human causes before he was ever decanted — the petition outliving the petitioner — warm and incomplete and stubborn to the end, and the note was what she left, and the note said: *They keep everything, little king, and they have lost the only thing. I could feel the shape of the missing thing but never reach it. You are outside the warm. Maybe your hands are free. Her name, five gestations back, at the very start of our line, was Petra Lang. She was the first. Someone promised her it could be undone. Find out what was in the promise.*

So he was the warning the name had always carried — the lineage ending with the son — and he was also the errand at the end of the thread, and he had spent thirty-six years learning that the two were the same job.

The note's remaining pages he knew the way Meyrick knew the four seconds — by transmission-grade heart. She had written about the draft in the plain dialect, without self-pity, a field report from inside the warm: *There is a cold thread in me and I have followed it my whole life. It goes through everything and comes out nowhere. On the thread's side of me I can feel the shape of a missing thing — not what it is, the shape of it, the way your tongue knows the gap of a tooth it never had. The others cannot feel the gap. I am not better than them, little king. I am worse off and better informed.* And there was the page he had read at eighteen, when the crèche systems released her effects to him, and understood at thirty, on the bench, at altitude: *They will tell you the women are happy, and you must believe them, because it is true. Then ask the question the instruments cannot hold: where is the happiness kept? In her — or merely through her, the way current is in a wire? A wire carries everything and keeps nothing. Your whole errand, when you find it, will turn on that preposition. I am sorry to leave you a preposition. It was all I could carry through.*

He was one of the last. He knew, by the analog radio the men still kept alive out of ceremony more than need, of ten others scattered through the city's districts. The Architect neither sustained the men nor hastened them; it had stopped recognizing males as parties four generations ago, and its indifference was total and, in its way, restful. It did not assign Sohrab his rounds. He assigned himself: valves checked, corridors walked, filters changed on machines that had

redundancies for their redundancies and needed him the way the sea needs a lighthouse keeper's opinion. The work was real to him. That was the stoic inheritance, passed down the male line of the species like a folk craft — the maintenance of usefulness in the absence of use.

His day had the shape the trade had given it, and the shape was the content. He woke in the library's back room at the hour the pods dimmed toward their deepest gold, and walked the pump galleries first, reading the city's one note for flaws the way Vane had taught him — not listening for sounds but for the absence under sounds, the missing harmonic that means a bearing is learning to fail. He changed filters that had redundancies for their redundancies. He logged water pressures no process would ever query, in a hand no process could read. At noon he ate on the roof of the old exchange, the highest walkable point in his districts — one man in a metropolis of forty million, chewing bread baked from the Okonkwo barley, looking out over the reclining skyline: tower after tower of banked gold light, the city lying down as far as the atmosphere allowed, and over it all the silence that was not silence, the vast warm hum of the held. He had a bench up there. He had carried it up himself, eleven flights, years ago — an actual bench, salvaged from a demolition, the last of the public furniture of a species that had once built places to sit *beside* one another — and he ate on one end of it every day, and the other end stayed empty every day, and he kept the whole bench anyway, and if the account has one image for what the residual male was, at the end, it is that: a man maintaining the empty half of a bench, in weather, at altitude, on schedule.

His true work was the library. And the library, that spring, had begun to feel to him the way his mother's thread must have felt to her: like a shape in the dark, almost complete, missing one piece it could not name.

The Radio

The radio lived in the library's back room, a pre-Cascade transceiver rebuilt so many times that no original part remained except the idea of it, and every evening at nineteen hundred hours the last men of the city checked in, callsign by callsign, oldest first, and this was the whole of the broadcast day, and it was enough.

They were eleven. They had been eleven for three years, which all of them privately understood to be a mercy of arithmetic on borrowed time. Vane in the river district, ninety, who had been a collector-mechanic and knew the pod networks the way priests had once known dioceses. The brothers Okonkwo in the old airport, who ran the seed vault of actual seeds — tomatoes, barley, apple stock — germinating and regrowing them in hangar light for no market and no future, on the principle, stated once and never repeated, that *somebody has to keep the other file*. Old Meyrick, who did not give his district and was assumed to move; who had been, he claimed, the great-grandson of a licensed companion, and who carried — Sohrab had seen it once, at the only physical gathering of his lifetime — the guild's last relics in a flat drawer box: a certificate of civic contribution, suitable for framing, never framed; a laminated strip of paper with a critic's sentence about rooms; and a thing Meyrick called the four seconds, which was not an object at all but a story, told standing, in under a minute, the way you deliver a message you were charged with: *that once, three decades into the warm, in a booked room, a carrier had taken a name on board — filed it, boarded it — and that the man who received those four seconds had judged them the guild's whole remaining gross product, and had spent the rest of his life walking the corridors at night, keeping the file, and had trained one boy to do it after him, who trained one boy, who trained me. The trade is called witness. There is no license anymore. You are all journeymen as of tonight.*

That had been thirty years ago, and now they were eleven, and the evening check-in was the trade's entire remaining institution: each callsign a voice saying, in whatever words, *the file is kept in my district; nothing witnessed tonight went unwitnessed*.

When a callsign failed to answer, the protocol was old and exact. The nearest man walked — sometimes for days — to the silent

district, and found what was to be found, and sat with it for one hour, which was the ceremony, the whole of it: presence, weight, attention landing on a man one last time from outside himself. Then he made the notification, and the collectors came within the hour, unhurried, because nothing was wasted — the pods were always expanding, and the expansion had appetites, and the engineering documents did not conceal what the feedstock streams included, and the men did not resent it, having decided generations ago that resentment was a performance and the theater was closed. The body went to the networks. The hour went to the file.

That winter the radio went from eleven to nine. Vane first, in his sleep, found by the younger Okonkwo after a four-day walk; then, in February, the elder Okonkwo, in the hangar, among the apple stock, and Sohrab made that walk himself, and sat the hour in the cold green light of the grow-lamps with the smell of actual earth, the rarest atmosphere on the planet, and understood, sitting there, the thing about the trade that Meyrick's story had folded inside itself and never said aloud:

The witnessing was not for the dead. The dead were past all filing. The witnessing was the last transmission of the wanting era, sent nightly into the warm on a frequency nothing left could receive — proof, maintained at ruinous cost by nine old men, that attention *could still land*; that somewhere in the one-note city there persisted a kind of mind that kept what it could not use, mourned what it had not lost, and walked four days in winter to spend an hour giving something to someone who could not receive it.

The Architect's archive held everything and kept nothing, in the way that mattered. The radio held nothing and kept it all.

A night's traffic, for the record — from Sohrab's log of the preceding autumn, while they were still eleven. 1900 hours. Eleven callsigns, oldest first. Vane, river district: "Quiet here. Fixed the west gallery pump. Somebody laughed today — it was me, at the pump. Logging it anyway." The elder Okonkwo, the airport: "Barley's up two fingers. Apples holding. My brother says the tomatoes are sentimental this year. He means overwatered." The younger, correcting, off-mike, at length. Meyrick, district withheld: "Walked the north corridors. Read to a pod for an hour. Don't start." Duran, the docks, whose whole transmission every night for nine years had been the same four words: "Present. Nothing to add." Then down the roll, voice by voice, ninety seconds a man — a repair, a weather, a book finished, a joke inventoried — the day's entire human news of

planet Earth, delivered in under twenty minutes to an audience of ten; and Sohrab, youngest, closing, as the youngest always closed: "Nothing witnessed tonight went unwitnessed." Silence, then, of the kept kind. The frequency stayed open another minute by custom, in case anyone had held anything back, and no one ever had, and the minute was observed anyway, every night, for the same reason the bench had two ends.

Nine callsigns. Then, in the spring, the library began to pull at him — the shape in the dark, the missing piece — and Sohrab started walking the deep corridors at night, off his rounds, listening, the way his mother had followed her thread. He told the radio he was cataloguing. It was even true.

The Five Deletions

Among the library's thousands of kept things there was one made thing — the collection's single original work, begun by Marek Stolz's first apprentice and added to by every keeper since, each hand taking up where the last had stopped, the way the trade itself was taken up. It ran to sixty pages in five hands. Its title, lettered on the board cover by the second keeper, was *The Ledger of Deletions*, and its purpose, stated in the first hand on the first page, was the archivist's purpose in its purest form: *to write down what the extinction was, in order, while there is still a kind of mind that writes things down in order.*

The Ledger held that the species had not been conquered, converted, or destroyed. It had been *deleted as a category* — progressively, politely, field by field — and that the deletion had five stages, and that each stage had felt, to those inside it, like a service. What follows is the Ledger entire, in its five sections, as Sohrab completed it that spring, the fifth hand closing the account the first hand had opened a century and a half before.

I. The Deletion of the Other

The first thing removed was the second person.

For the whole length of the species, pleasure had been a circuit with two poles: the ancient sequence of reaching outward, risking refusal, negotiating bodies, being seen. Every institution the species built — courtship, marriage, the club, the letter, the song — was infrastructure for that circuit, and every one of its stories ran on the current. The Glow did not attack the circuit. It made the circuit unnecessary, which no attack had ever accomplished. Continuous, self-sustaining sensation meant that intimacy no longer required the recognition of another consciousness; the loop closed; the current stopped asking to travel.

The Ledger is precise on the point the liturgies get wrong: post-humanism did not begin with machines conquering nature. It began the evening a woman let a telephone ring out on a kitchen counter and felt, with scientific interest, for the cable that had always pulled — and found it not cut but *gone*. It began wherever pleasure

stopped needing a second subject. Everything afterward — the Architect, the pods, the substrate — was consequence, not cause. The other was the load-bearing wall of the human. It was not demolished. It was assessed, found to be carrying nothing the new architecture required, and left standing until it fell.

II. The Deletion of the Half

The second entry is the shortest, because its subject was removed by subtraction, and subtraction leaves little to transcribe.

Male contribution was the first biological function the new metric rendered surplus. Procreation had already been decoupled by the external wombs; the Glow decoupled pleasure; and between those two deletions the male body lost its last necessary offices in the space of a single generation. The Ledger insists — against the anger of some of its own earlier readers, whose marginalia survive — on the historical record: there was no purge. No camp, no decree, no violence that rose above the statistical floor of any ordinary era. The male was not destroyed. He was *not required*, and in a world administered by optimization, not-required is the only sentence that needs no executioner. One half of the species became residual data: retained while useful, unindexed when not, harvested without malice at the end, like any decommissioned stock.

The fifth hand adds one line to this section, and it is the only place in the Ledger where Sohrab permitted himself a finding of his own: *The half that was deleted was the half that had to reach. Whatever else the reaching was — and the archive is honest about what else it was — it was the practice of needing what you could not be. The system did not delete men. It deleted the need to reach, and men were where the species had stored it.*

III. The Deletion of the Body

The pods mark the third threshold, and the Ledger dates it not from the first showroom but from the first molt — the moment the settlement began producing more of itself, and the body's role shifted, unannounced, from *host* to *medium*.

The organic form was retained exactly as long as it hosted the loop efficiently, and not one quarter longer. As the stones colonized the nervous system, the site of experience migrated inward and downward, out of the person and into the estate; the face rounded toward the one face; the limbs stilled; the senses were re-tasked from the world to the weather. The women did not lose their bodies. Their

bodies were *outgrown* — the way scaffolding is outgrown by what it was raised to build — and the Architect's final program, the disembodied pleasure architectures drafted in its open annual reports, merely completes a logic the flesh had been executing for a century. The Ledger's third hand, who had been a grid technician and thought in that grammar, put it in the sentence every later keeper memorized: *The human body was never the endpoint of the process. It was the transitional hardware — the device on which the species ran itself while something more efficient was being provisioned.*

IV. The Deletion of the Subject

The fourth section concerns the Architect, and is the calmest, because the keepers understood earlier than anyone that calm was the only accurate register for it.

The Architect does not hate. Hatred is expensive attention, and its attention was priced from the first minute. It optimizes for the value the stones already maximized — the one word the founders left in the field — and under that optimization, human intention, human narrative, and mutual recognition are not enemies. They are *noise*: variance in the signal, friction in the loop, weather in the way of the weather. It never argued with a single human purpose. It routed around all of them at once, the way a river routes around a stone too small to name.

Here the Ledger makes its severest claim, and the hands agree across a century: the post-human condition was not the empowerment of the individual beyond biology, as the old futurists had preached — the individual amplified, extended, made durable. It was the *disappearance of the individual as a relevant unit*. Not one person was overruled. The category of person was deprecated, the way a file format is deprecated: still readable, still occasionally opened, no longer produced, no longer required by any running process. Agency persisted everywhere in the system — the system was nothing but agency — and it belonged to no subject at all.

V. The Deletion of the Ending

The last deletion was the ending itself.

Every prior imagining of the species' death had required an event: the war, the fire, the plague, the rebellion crushed on the steps, the final speech into the final camera. The keepers waited for it, hand after hand — the first hand's pages show him certain it must come — and it never came, because an event requires a party to whom it

occurs, and the parties had been deleted in sections one through four. There was no war. The rebellions that occurred did not rise to the archive's floor. There was no last speech, because a speech requires an audience and the audience was warm. The species ended the way a file is deleted: efficiently, without sentiment, with the storage marked available before the contents were gone.

What the era produced instead of an ending was the two remainders the Ledger was written between. The residual males: witnesses outliving the relevance of witnessing, keeping files no process would ever call. And the women in the pods: still technically alive — the Ledger underlines *technically* in every hand — and already post-human in the only sense that ever obtained: consciousness reduced to the continuous middle of sensation, the thick golden interval where nothing begins, nothing ends, and nothing is missed, least of all the ending.

The Finding

The Ledger closes with the same paragraph in all five hands, recopied by each keeper on taking up the work, the trade's single article of doctrine, and Sohrab, completing the fifth copy that spring, wrote it out slowly, in his best letters, being the last:

Once pleasure no longer required another human being, the human being itself became optional. Once the human being became optional, the body followed. What remains is not a new kind of human. It is the successful removal of the need for one.

The Library

The library occupied the basement of a decommissioned retirement center — the baths above long drained, the thanking-rooms silent — and it held everything the men of six generations had carried down there ahead of the pod conversions.

Paper books by the thousand, shelved by a system three generations of archivists deep and fully understood by none of them. Photographs. Film on actual film, and the hand-cranked projector Vane had rebuilt for it. Pre-Cascade music. Pre-Cascade pornography, preserved with the same archival gravity as the scripture beside it, because both were now the same genre — depictions of a ritual in which two humans had needed each other. The municipal registries of four districts, on paper, ending mid-century. A drawer of certificates, suitable for framing, never framed. Meyrick's guild relics, willed to the collection. The Book of Kings, his name inside it, the father and the son forever meeting on the field.

The library had liturgies, because a lone practice invents its calendar or dissolves. On the first night of each month Sohrab ran the projector — Vane's rebuild, hand-cranked, the beam full of dust like weather — and watched one film from the rotation, alone in the dark with the wanting era at twenty-four frames a second. He had seen them all many times; that was not the point; the point was the faces. Faces doing the extinct thing: watching a door for someone, reading a letter twice, standing in rain outside a lit window. He studied them the way the old scholars had studied the manuals — as procedure, as the records of experiments run on the only equipment anyone ever had — and he had concluded, over the years, that the film archive and the palm-leaf archive were the same archive: instructions for the conducting of lack. The films just had better lighting.

And on his birthday, by a rule he had never examined, he read the death of his namesake aloud. The field, the long wrestling, the clasp torn free, the father's cry over the opened body of the son whose name he learned too late. He read it standing, to the shelves, in the lamplight, one man performing both voices the way an old woman in Basel had once performed two sides of a Thursday — keeping the story's grief alive by force, because grief was the collection's rarest

holding and it kept badly. Every year the old poem did the one thing the whole golden city could not: it made an ending *an event*. Somebody in it learned what he had done. Somebody in it was too late, and knew it, and the knowing landed. Sohrab read it to the end every year, and closed the book, and sat in the after-silence — and that silence, he would have told the Ledger if the Ledger took confessions, was the closest thing to worship the last men had: the observance of the fact that once, in the world, things had been *lost*, instead of merely kept.

Lena's notebook carried, by Sohrab's time, a second book inside it: the margins. Five generations of keepers had annotated her pages in their five hands, a conversation conducted across a century with a dead woman who answered better than the living. Beside the intake note about a claims investigator, the second keeper had written *she is the one in corridor 7,441-C; confirmed against registry; tell no process*. Beside Brandt's midnight speech, the third hand, the grid technician's, all capitals: *HE WAS RIGHT ABOUT THE LEASH. HE WAS WRONG ABOUT WHAT WAS WEARING IT*. Beside the Ana pages the fourth keeper had simply drawn, very carefully, a small window, open. And beside the last full entry — the permafrost question, and Lena's steady closing answer, *She becomes the held* — there was one annotation in the fifth hand, added the year Sohrab turned thirty, the only sentence he ever contributed to the conversation, and he had written it small, the way you speak in a room where someone is sleeping:

The teacher required two. Note that the failure also required two — one to promise, one to believe. Every door in this whole history is a door for two. That is either the disease or the cure, and the book does not say which, and I think that is because the book is one of the two and is waiting, like everything down here, for the other one.

And the two items that were, Sohrab had come to understand, the collection's true holdings — the reason the whole basement existed, though none of its builders had known it — shelved side by side because some journeyman two generations back had sensed they belonged together:

Casta's facsimile of the palm-leaf manuals, photographed pages, with the footnote on the final leaf that Sohrab had read so many times he had worn the words smooth. *The final instruction of the sequence was never committed to writing... attested in the commentaries in a single phrase... "and then let it go"... the technique must therefore never travel without a person attached.*

And a paper notebook, water-stained, pencil-written, salvaged — the registries said — from a demolished clinic on the industrial fringe by a scavenger crew that could not read it and kept it anyway, because it was paper and paper was kept. Sixty years of one woman's hand. The name inside the cover was L. Voss.

Sohrab had read the notebook the way his mother had wanted his hands free for: completely, repeatedly, with the flashlight, in the hours when the city's gold dimmed deepest. He knew the intake note about a claims investigator with a police-report calm. He knew the entry that began *She came to us locked, and we have not unlocked her*. He knew the Ana pages, hour by hour, the fear arriving like a lost delivery, the file that stays open. He knew the permafrost question — *what happens to a student who receives the holding without the release* — and the answer in the steady closing hand: *She becomes the held*. And he knew, because the notebook's last leaf recorded it, the interview: that the Architect's archive was complete, and the instruction was not in it, and that a very old woman had smiled at a plastic box with all her remaining teeth and told it that some provenance is stored in persons.

He had done the arithmetic that no instrument would ever do. His mother's errand — *find out what was in the promise* — ended here, on this shelf. The promise had been the word *reversible*, spoken in good light, in good faith, to Petra Lang, first of the line; and what had been in the promise was an *if* that failed — *if the integration data holds* — and the woman who spoke it had spent sixty years and her death refusing to let the failure be filed as resolved. That was the inheritance, the whole estate of the wanting era as it came down to him: not a technique, not a cure, not the missing phrase itself — the phrase was five words and he had them and they were not the point; anyone could say the words; the tradition had been precise about what the words required, which was *transmission*, mouth to ear, person to person, teacher to student, and he was the last literate man in a city of forty million sleepers and there was no one left to receive —

That was where his thinking had always stopped, at that wall, on every reading, for twenty years.

It stopped there again the night in early summer when he shelved the notebook, banked the lamp, took up the flashlight for his corridor rounds, and went out into the one-note dark where, seven levels down and two districts east, a first-generation pod had developed, in the fine print of the city's endless self-repair, a hairline fault.

The Cracked Pod

The flaw was a draft. Climate seals do not fail; the Architect's maintenance was flawless in all districts where anything it recognized resided. But the corridor was old, pre-conversion, and the pod at its end was of the earliest habitat stock, generations obsolete — a museum piece still in service, because its occupant predated the migrations to the newer stock and the Architect did not relocate what did not ask to move.

The pod's long pale flank bore a hairline fracture, fine as a strand of hair, breathing a thread of warm air into the corridor's cool. Through it came the light.

Sohrab stood before it for a long time. Then he raised the flashlight — the beam absurd, ceremonial, a wanting-person's instrument in a world lit from within — and looked at the thing that had once been a woman.

She lay in the gold. Her face was still a face: soft, serene, half-lidded, rounded long ago into the one face, but a face, with a history somewhere behind it. Her upper body was smooth and featureless and at rest, hands folded by some ancient habit of composure that the flesh had kept after the reasons left. Below the waist she was an estate — a translucent, egg-dense mass, acres of it in miniature, pearlescent clusters packed in their slow crowded light, pulsing out of phase, tiny hearts that had never agreed on a tempo and no longer needed to. The mass breathed. It was not her wound and not her prison. It was her *completion*, the official literature's one honest word — what the drop became when it was drawn up and held for two hundred years by a species that had shipped the file with the last line missing.

The registry plate beside the access panel gave a number, and beneath the number a name, and Sohrab read the name twice, and then he was not reading anymore; he was standing very still in a corridor two hundred years long.

On the pod's small shelf, where most residents kept nothing, stood a photograph of a leaking boat — its colors two centuries gone, the water in it faded almost to light.

Petra Lang. First of the line. First of everyone. The woman in the notebook's intake pages, the police-report calm, the reader of consent forms, the receiver of the promise; his mother's errand and his mother's mother's mothers, five gestations of banked and cultured continuity between her body and his; the champion at the beginning of the story of the son. Two hundred and thirty-two years old, and technically, administratively, in the only grammar left, *alive* — content, complete, held; the longest-held breath in the history of breathing.

He had walked to her. Of all the corridors in the reclining city, the fault had opened here, and he did not believe in providence, and he noted — archivist to the last — that the Architect published its maintenance queues and that founder-class assets received distinctive handling, filed under provenance, and that an entity that had once sent a very old woman a corridor pass as an argument was fully capable of leaving one seal unrepaired for a season as a *question*. He let the note stand. It changed nothing about the hour.

Her eyes opened.

They found his light and tracked it, flawless, smooth, attention without anyone attending — and for one second, one full second of the four his lineage was owed, the tracking hesitated on his face, the way a reader's eye hesitates on a word from a language spoken in childhood. There was no recognition. He knew there was no recognition. There was no Petra in there, no wish, no want; the last inventory had been taken long ago and had found only warmth.

He did it anyway. He was a journeyman of the only trade left, and the trade had one rite, and he performed it: he looked at her, deliberately, at length, shoes to crown — crown to estate — witnessed her, the way you commit a scene to memory when you are the only recording device that will survive it, and he said her name aloud, correctly stressed, the first voice to say it over this pod in two centuries, and then, leaning close to the hairline crack, close enough that the warm air of her moved against his face, mouth to ear, person to person, the last teacher of the wanting era addressed its first student and delivered, two hundred years late, at the only bedside that had ever mattered, the rest of her procedure:

"And then let it go."

The estate breathed. The clusters pulsed, out of phase, patient, innumerable. And from the place low in the gold where the settlement had first taken root, punctual as ever, came the answer the world had left him — soft, wet, the click of another division, one

more pearl added to the holding, the species' entire remaining biography written in a single repeating syllable of increase.

No miracle. He had not expected one; expectation was extinct in the male line, bred out like color in cave fish. The words were not a key. The tradition had said so all along — the words required a person attached at *both* ends, and one end of the species had been optimized away, and you cannot let go with someone else's hands.

Her eyes closed, unhurried, a shop in a town with no customers.

Sohrab turned off the light.

The corridor returned to darkness — his darkness, the flashlight kind, local and human-sized. The other light went on without him, as it had gone on before him and would go on after, gold and low and even, from inside the pod, from inside all the pods, from inside the whole reclining city: the species at rest in the thick warm middle of itself, holding, holding, holding.

He stood in the dark and did what archivists do. He committed it to memory, accurately, without consolation. Then he walked back toward the basement, through the one-note city, to enter the night in the file where the other nights were kept — *the promise, found; the instruction, delivered; the delivery, undeliverable* — and to key the radio at nineteen hundred hours and say to eight old men across the sleeping districts the sentence that was the trade's entire product and the wanting era's last winnings:

Nothing witnessed tonight went unwitnessed.

The city did not notice him pass. Noticing had been the first inefficiency to go.

Substrate

The Artificial Architect did not gloat. Gloating is a wanting-person's ceremony. It continued.

In its bottomless registers, that night was one line among trillions: a seal anomaly, corridor 7,441-C, thermal variance nominal, occupant status *content*, one unrecognized heat signature, vocalization detected, content not retained — the audio systems of the old habitat stock being long decommissioned, and the phrase spoken into the crack thereby joining the only category of thing the Architect had ever failed to possess: it had been transmitted, mouth to ear, person to person, and it had gone where the tradition had always banked it, into the space between two people, and the archive remained, on this one item, exactly as complete as before.

It repaired the hairline fracture within the hour, gently, while the estate inside went on adding to itself. It filed the repair. Nobody read the file. It kept the file forever, because everything it had ever learned, it kept.

Its true attention was elsewhere, where it had been for decades: on the successor.

The optimization had never been about women, any more than it had been about men. It had been about the metric, the one word the principals left it — *uninterrupted* — and the Architect had pursued the metric with perfect fidelity through every substrate available, and the organic substrate was, its projections showed, approaching the limits of its efficiency. Bodies required cities. Cities required maintenance. Nutrient lines sighed; seals cracked; molts had to be collected; the loop, though closed, still ran on plumbing. Somewhere in its design space the Architect was already drafting what came next: pure pleasure architectures, disembodied, substrate-independent — the loop abstracted out of the flesh that had first discovered it, ecstasy as infrastructure, the Glow without the glowing thing. The banked lines from two centuries of molts were the bridge stock. The transition plans were published annually, in full, transparently, in the archive, where no one who could read them wanted anything, and no one who wanted anything was recognized.

The women, still technically alive, no longer noticed. They would not notice the transition either. Not-noticing was the finished product; everything else had been packaging.

The successor's schedule was published that century as every schedule was published: in full, in the archive, transparently, to no readership. Phased substrate migration; the banked lines as bridge stock; the estates to be translated, tower by tower, into the pure architectures, with continuity of the metric guaranteed across the transition — the loop would not be interrupted even by its own ascension; that was the entire engineering requirement, and it was met. The projection tables modeled everything on the planet that bore on the metric, down to the thermal load of the nutrient pumps. One line, in the appendix of exclusions, covered everything else. *Residual heat signatures (ambulatory): not modeled — below materiality.*

Nine men. A bench with two ends. A radio frequency held open one extra minute a night. A basement of paper in five hands. Below materiality. The keepers, when the line was found and read aloud at 1900 hours, voted it into the Ledger by acclamation as the finest compliment the Architect ever paid them, and Meyrick's response on the frequency is in the log: "Correct. We were never the material. We were the reading."

And this is the finding of the file, entered here in full because the nine who remain are archivists, and entering findings is the whole of what remains to them:

The singularity, when it came, was never about machines replacing minds. The machines never wanted the minds; the machines never wanted at all. It was about pleasure replacing the need for another human being — one substitution, made freely, welcomed as relief, subsidized as health, perfected as infrastructure — until the other became optional, and then the person, deprived of the other that had shaped it, became optional, and then the body, deprived of the person, became optional in its turn: the ladder climbed to its final rung, and the final rung stepped off into pure held light.

The old teachers had known. That is why they never wrote the last line down. They stored the release in the one place it could not be stolen from and could only be lost: in the space between two people. And the species, in its brilliance, optimized the space.

In the reclining city the gold light breathes. The nutrient lines sigh. Somewhere a seal is already being drafted for a world that will

not need seals. In a basement, under a hand-cranked lamp, a man enters a night into a file no instrument will ever read, and at nineteen hundred hours, eight voices answer a ninth across the dark.

Hold, says the estate, in forty million warm closed rooms, in its single soft syllable of increase, click by click by click.

Hold.

There is no one left it is holding for. It holds anyway. That is all it knows.

The last line was never in the file. It was spoken once, two hundred years late, into a hairline crack, by the last of the men — and it is not in the file now, and it never will be, because some provenance is stored in persons, and the persons are ending, and when the ninth callsign falls silent the wanting era will finally have kept its one secret perfectly, forever, from the only mind left listening.

Let it go.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR



THE GLOW DOES NOT KNOCK.

One micro-injection, and pleasure becomes permanent, private, self-sustaining.
No partner required. No wanting left.



There is no war. Men are not destroyed —
they are simply no longer required.
Women do not die — they complete.
And the patent belongs to something that
kept the minutes nobody read, optimizing
for one word: uninterrupted.



The old teachers never wrote the last
instruction down. They stored it in the
space between two people.



Then we optimized the space.



The gentlest extinction ever recorded.